

EXECUTIVE MBA

FALL 2024

Leadership Communication

EMBA 60

Professor Catherine Dunkin

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Leadership Communication
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Fall 2024
Professor Catherine Dunkin
The Olin Business School

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Washington University in St. Louis

OLIN BUSINESS SCHOOL

Catherine S. Dunkin, APR
Professor of Practice, Management Communication

Fall 2024

RE: MGT 702E - Leadership Communication

Hello, EMBA 60!

Prior to our class in December, I plan to deliver a preview of our Leadership Communication course along with your course packs, including the syllabus, readings, other assignments, and background materials. Following that course preview, you also will be able to access our Canvas website with the additional modules, materials, and instructions you will need to prepare for our class sessions on Thursday through Saturday, Dec. 5-7.

Over our three class days, we will cover important communication competencies in three areas:

- Thursday, Dec. 5: The Individual Leader
- Friday, Dec. 6: The Organization
- Saturday, Dec. 7: Stakeholders and Reputation Management

I encourage you to jump into the Canvas site and course pack right away to *complete the early assignment (speaker survey due Friday, Nov. 15)* and prepare for our first day of class. Please contact me anytime with questions about the course or just to introduce yourself and discuss your goals for our time together.

I look forward to meeting and working with you!

Sincerely,

Cathy

Cathy Dunkin, APR, Fellow PRSA

MGT 702E: LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION
COMMUNICATION@OLIN

Washington University in St. Louis
Olin Business School

DECEMBER 5-7, 2024

INSTRUCTOR

Catherine S. (Cathy) Dunkin, APR, Fellow PRSA
Professor of Practice, Management Communication
Email: cdunkin@wustl.edu
Phone: (314) 518.4931
Office Hours: By appointment

COURSE OVERVIEW:

Top business leaders must align, inspire, and engage others to achieve important organizational goals. This course will help students develop communication competencies in four areas recognized as critical contributors to leadership success:

1. Demonstrating Respect.
2. Active Listening.
3. Relationship Building.
4. Exercising Emotional Intelligence.

Learning Objectives:

In this class students will learn to:

- Use critical thinking skills to analyze and evaluate organizational opportunities and challenges.
- Develop strategies for cultivating emotional intelligence, executive presence, and values-based business communication.
- Understand and consider the crucial differences and needs of varied and diverse stakeholder groups.
- Develop and communicate clear, focused, empathetic, and effective written and oral communications to accomplish desired business results among key stakeholders.
- Strengthen skills in problem-solving, persuasion, and advocacy appropriate to business contexts.

Course assignments and in-class exercises will reinforce concepts and create opportunities for additional practice in communicating business leadership messages with clarity, focus, and empathy. We will emphasize critical thinking, organization, writing, oral presentations, and effective meeting facilitation. Professional guests will reinforce important concepts and encourage lively discussion based on experience.

Olin's Pillars of Excellence:

This course will support all four pillars of Olin's Strategic Plan:

1. Embody a values-based and data-driven ethos in their approach to all business situations.
2. Understand the global opportunities and challenges facing businesses.
3. Engage with business issues through the application of experiential knowledge, in addition to the rigorous technical skills acquired in the classroom.
4. Pursue world-changing initiatives with an entrepreneurial and innovative mindset and skillset.

Schedule:

This class will meet in person on three consecutive days:

- Thursday, Dec. 5: 8:00 a.m. – 12:30 p.m.
- Friday, Dec. 6: 8:00 a.m. – 12:30 p.m.
- Saturday, Dec. 7: 8:00 a.m. – 12:30 p.m.

Students will be expected to complete prework in anticipation of first-day assignments, as well as overnight individual and team assignments.

CLASS SESSIONS/TOPICS:

Over the three days, we will complete sections related to important communication competencies that represent core leadership attributes of an effective executive. Especially in today's complex global economy, successful leaders must think critically and communicate clearly with all stakeholders to take advantage of opportunities and manage challenges – including personal, professional and organizational.

We will approach assignments and discussions from the point of view of a senior executive who needs to communicate effectively as an individual leader, inspire work teams to take advantage of opportunities, and successfully manage difficult situations that may arise, including crises.

We will address a different aspect of leadership communication each day:

Part 1 – Thursday, Dec. 5 – Focus on the Individual Leader**Topics:**

- Developing your effective leadership communication style and "Personal Leadership Brand."
- Cultivating executive presence.
- Developing messages and storytelling skills.
- Preparing effective written communication.
- Developing and giving professional speeches and presentations.

Part 2 – Friday, Dec. 6 – Focus on the Organization**Topics:**

- Communicating effectively in organizations.
 - Internal considerations.
 - External considerations.
 - Special focus on emails, meeting facilitation and HR communications.

- Analyzing stakeholders.
 - Including discussion of the business case for consideration of ESG and DEI (Environment/Social/Government and Diversity/Equity/Inclusion).
- Giving executive business presentations with positive impact.
 - Individual leaders.
 - Business teams.

Part 3– Saturday, Dec.7 – Focus on Stakeholders and Reputation Management

Topics:

- Critical thinking and communication strategy.
- Handling marketing communication and media relations.
- Developing and communicating effective messaging for your organization.
- Managing communication in a crisis.
- Becoming a thought leader: importance and process.

ASSIGNMENTS AND RESOURCES

Prior to our class sessions in December, I will join you for a course preview to help you prepare for our time together. I will share your MGT 702E Course Pack and Canvas website and discuss expectations and course assignments in detail and answer any questions you may have.

Important pre-course preparation: Your success in this course depends upon preparation prior to and during our sessions. Please make sure that you read all assigned readings. ***In particular, please be aware that I would like you to complete a personal speaking assessment more than a week prior to the class and submit it to Canvas no later than 11:59 p.m., Friday, Nov. 15.*** Completing this assessment will help me prepare the course content to meet your EMBA 59 cohort's individual needs more effectively.

COURSE GRADE

Your final grade will be determined by your performance on the various readings, discussions, and assignments in the course. You must attend all class sessions and successfully complete all assignments to pass the course.

Your grade will be determined based on the following individual and group assignments:

- | | |
|--|-------------------------|
| • Speaking Survey | 250 points (individual) |
| • Personal Leadership Brand | 250 points (individual) |
| • Stakeholder Analysis | 300 points (individual) |
| • Discussion, Participation, Timeliness of Assignments | 200 Points (individual) |
| • Message Map | 300 points (group) |
| • Media Conference | 300 points (group) |

You may earn one of four grades for your work in this course:

- | | |
|-------------|---|
| • High Pass | Exceeded expectations – top 20 percent of the class |
| • Pass | Fulfilled expectations |
| • Low Pass | Barely meet expectations |
| • No Pass | Failed to meet expectations |



COURSE INSTRUCTOR

Cathy Dunkin is a Professor of Practice in the Olin Business School at Washington University in St. Louis. She teaches management communication courses for graduate students and business executives, helping them communicate ideas effectively in writing or orally to accomplish various business objectives. Olin's communication courses help students gain important insights about understanding diverse audiences, creating effective speech and presentation content, preparing persuasive arguments, and developing professional visuals.

Before joining the Olin faculty in 2013, Cathy founded and built a public relations firm, Standing Partnership, recognized for its positive employee culture, exceptional client results, and innovative leadership as a partner in the global Worldcom Public Relations Group. Cathy and her team at Standing were recognized nationally for creativity, company management and growth, and creating a "best place to work." She previously held positions with Fortune 500 companies and global agencies in St. Louis, Chicago and Dallas. She is a graduate of the University of Missouri School of Journalism.

IMPORTANT OLIN AND WASHINGTON UNIVERSITY INFORMATION

COVID-19 Health and Safety Protocols

Students experiencing symptoms consistent with COVID-19 or concerned about a possible exposure should contact Habif Health and Wellness Center (314 935-6666) to arrange for testing as indicated. If a student tests positive for Covid-19, they will receive a letter with instructions about any necessary isolation that they can share with their instructors. ****Update: 9/1/23. Illness activity at the start of the semester is high, and students may not have documentation of their COVID status; instructors should NOT request students provide them with results of PCR tests to receive an excused absence. During this time, please extend grace to students who indicate a need to isolate and allow their absence so that we may reduce the likelihood of illnesses being transmitted in our classrooms.**** Any accommodation needs for COVID-related absence not covered in an instructor's standard course policies should be discussed between the student and instructor.

While on campus, it is imperative that students follow all public health guidelines established to reduce the risk of COVID-19 transmission within our community. The full set of University protocols can be found on the [Health and Safety webpage](#). This includes:

Masking

Masking remains a valuable tool in the mitigation of COVID-19, particularly in light of new and emerging variants. Students and instructors are encouraged to treat requests to mask with care and consideration, keeping in mind that some individuals may be at a higher risk, caring for others at a higher risk, or feeling less comfortable in a mask-optional environment. Based on monitoring of regional and campus conditions, a mask requirement may be implemented as needed.

Students with disabilities for whom masked instructors or classmates create a communication barrier are encouraged to contact Disability Resources (www.disability.wustl.edu) or talk to their instructor for assistance in determining reasonable adjustments. Adjustments may involve amplification devices, captioning, or clear masks but will not allow for the disregard of mask policies should a requirement be in place.

Reporting Sexual Assault and Harassment

If a student discusses or discloses an instance of sexual assault, sex discrimination, sexual harassment, dating violence, domestic violence or stalking, or if a faculty member otherwise observes or becomes aware of such an allegation, the faculty member will keep the information as private as possible, but as a faculty member of Washington University, they are required to immediately report it to the Department Chair or Dean or directly to Ms. Cynthia Copeland, the University's Associate Title IX Coordinator, at (314) 935-3411, cmcopeland@wustl.edu. They will also offer available resources, including confidential support resources through the Relationship and Sexual Violence Prevention (RSVP) at 314-935-3445. Additionally, you can report incidents or complaints to the Office of Student Conduct and Community Standards or by contacting WUPD at (314) 935-5555 or your local law enforcement agency. See: [Gender Equity and Title IX Compliance Office](#)

Disability Resources (DR)

WashU supports the right of all enrolled students to an equitable educational opportunity and strives to create an inclusive learning environment. In the event the physical or online environment results in barriers to the inclusion of a student due to a disability, they should notify the instructor as soon as possible.

Disabled students requiring adjustments to equitably complete expectations in this course should contact WashU's Disability Resources (DR) and engage in a process for determining and communicating reasonable accommodations. Because accommodations are not applied retroactively, DR recommends initiating requests prior to, or at the beginning of, the academic term to avoid delays in accessing accommodations once classes begin. Once established, responsibility for disability-related accommodations and access is shared by Disability Resources, faculty, and the student. Disability Resources: <http://www.disability.wustl.edu/>; 314-935-5970.

Religious Holidays

As home to students, faculty, and staff of all the world's major religions and as a non-sectarian institution, Washington University in St. Louis values the rich diversity of spiritual expression and practice found on campus. It is therefore the policy of the university that students who miss class, assignments, or exams to observe a religious holiday should be accommodated. The Religious Holiday Class Absence Policy can be found [here](#).

Statement on Military Service Leave

Washington University recognizes that students serving in the U.S. Armed Forces and their family members may encounter situations where military service forces them to withdraw from a course of study, sometimes with little notice. Students may contact the Office of Military and Veteran Services at (314) 935-2609 or veterans@wustl.edu and their academic dean for guidance and assistance. See: <https://veterans.wustl.edu/policies/policy-for-military-students/>.

Preferred Name and Personal Pronouns

Washington University in St. Louis recognizes that many students prefer to use names other than their legal ones to identify themselves. In addition, to affirm each person's gender identity and lived experiences, it is important that we ask and check in with others about pronouns. This simple effort can make a profound difference in a person's experience of safety, respect, and support.

See: <https://students.wustl.edu/pronouns-information/>, <https://registrar.wustl.edu/student-records/ssn-name-changes/preferred-name/>.

Emergency Preparedness

Before an emergency, familiarize yourself with the building(s) that you frequent. Know the layout, including exit locations, stairwells and the Emergency Assembly Point (EAP). Review the “Quick Guide for Emergencies” that is found near the door in many classrooms and main lobby areas of buildings for specific emergency information and instructions. For additional Information and EAP maps, visit <https://emergency.wustl.edu/>. To ensure that you receive emergency notifications, make sure your information and cell phone number is updated in SIS, and/or download the [WashU Safe app](#) and enable notifications.

To report an emergency:

Danforth Campus: (314) 935-5555

School of Medicine Campus: (314) 362-4357

North/West/South and Off Campus: 911 then (314) 935-5555

Academic Integrity and Code of Conduct Policies

Effective learning, teaching and research all depend upon the ability of members of the academic community to trust one another and to trust the integrity of work that is submitted for academic credit or conducted in the wider arena of scholarly research. Such an atmosphere of mutual trust fosters the free exchange of ideas and enables all members of the community to achieve their highest potential.

In all academic work, the ideas and contributions of others (including generative artificial intelligence) must be appropriately acknowledged and work that is presented as original must be, in fact, original. Faculty, students and administrative staff all share the responsibility of ensuring the honesty and fairness of the intellectual environment at Washington University in St. Louis.

As an instructor, I consistently and fully support Olin’s Academic Code of Conduct and Olin’s Code of Professional Conduct. I take the matters of academic integrity and professional conduct seriously and expect that you do, too. I encourage you to ask if you have any questions about academic integrity in this course.

The Olin Business School’s Academic Integrity Committee updated expectations for academic integrity for the 2023-2024 Academic Year to include language related to generative artificial intelligence. Olin’s policy explicitly requires students to cite the use of generative artificial intelligence as they would any other source.

In the EMBA Leadership Communication course (MGT 702E), I will clearly communicate the policies for instances when students are permitted to use this technology, prohibited from doing so, or restricted in some ways.

Washington University’s Code of Conduct may be revised from time to time. An up-to-date version of the Code will always be available on this website: <https://universitycompliance.wustl.edu/>. If you have any questions about the Code of Conduct, please contact the University Compliance Office at (314) 362-4915, or universitycompliance@wustl.edu.

Resources for Students

Confidential Resources for Instances of Sexual Assault, Sex Discrimination, Sexual Harassment, Dating Violence, Domestic Violence, or Stalking

The University is committed to offering reasonable academic accommodations (e.g., a no-contact order, course changes) to students who are victims of relationship or sexual violence, regardless of whether they seek a formal investigation or criminal charges. If a student needs to explore options for medical care, other services, or reporting, or would like to receive individual counseling services, there are free, confidential support resources and professional counseling services available through the Relationship and Sexual Violence Prevention (RSVP) Center. If you need to request such accommodations, please contact RSVP to schedule an appointment with a confidential and licensed counselor. Although information shared with counselors is confidential, requests for accommodations will be coordinated with the appropriate University administrators and faculty. The RSVP Center is located in Seigle Hall, Suite 435, and can be reached at rsvpcenter@wustl.edu or (314) 935-3445. For after-hours emergency response services, call the Sexual Assault and Rape Anonymous Helpline (SARAH) at (314) 935-8080 or call 314-935-6666 or (314) 935-5555 and ask to speak with an RSVP Counselor on call. See: [RSVP Center](#).

Bias Reporting and Support System (BRSS)

The University has a process through which students, faculty, staff, and community members who have experienced or witnessed incidents of bias, prejudice, or discrimination against a student can report their experiences to the University's Bias Report and Support System (BRSS) team. See: brss.wustl.edu.

Counseling and Psychological Services

Counseling and Psychological Services' professional staff members work with students to resolve personal and interpersonal difficulties, many of which can affect a student's academic experience. These include conflicts with or worry about friends or family, concerns about eating or drinking patterns, and feelings of anxiety, depression, and thoughts of suicide. Individual, Conjoint, and Group therapy are all provided in addition to referrals for off-campus support. Information can be found on the [Mental Health Services webpage](#).

The Division of Student Affairs also offers a telehealth program to students called [TimelyCare](#). While students are encouraged to visit Counseling and Psychological Services during business hours, this additional service also provides after-hours access to medical care and 24/7 access to mental telehealth care across the United States, with no cost at the time of the visit. Twelve counseling visits are provided at no charge as well as a limited number of psychiatry appointments. Students who pay the Health and Wellness fee are eligible for this service.

Additionally, see the mental health services offered through the RSVP Center listed above.

WashU Cares

WashU Cares specializes providing referrals and resources, both on, and off campus for mental health, medical health, financial and academic resources by using supportive case management. WashU Cares also receives reports on students who may need help connecting to resources or whom a campus partner is concerned about. If you are concerned about a student or yourself, you can file a report here: <https://washucares.wustl.edu/>.

The Writing Center

The Writing Center offers free writing support to all Washington University undergraduate and graduate students. Staff members will work with students on any kind of writing project, including essays, writing assignments, personal statements, theses, and dissertations. They can help at any stage of the process, including brainstorming, developing and clarifying an argument, organizing evidence, or improving style.

Instead of simply editing or proofreading papers, the tutors will ask questions and have a conversation with the writer about their ideas and reasoning, allowing for a higher order revision of the work. They will also spend some time looking at sentence level patterns to teach students to edit their own work.

The Center is located in Mallinckrodt and open Sunday through Thursday from 11:00 am to 9:00 pm and Friday from 11:00 am to 5:00 pm. Students are seen primarily by appointment, with walk-ins accepted as the schedule allows. They also have dedicated walk-in hours for undergraduates on Tuesday and Wednesday afternoons. Both in-person and online appointments are available. To make an appointment, go to writingcenter.wustl.edu. Email: writing@wustl.edu.

The Learning Center

The Learning Center provides [peer-led support programs](#), including course-specific mentoring and academic skills coaching (study and test-taking strategies, time management, etc.), that enhance undergraduate students' academic progress. Contact them at learningcenter@wustl.edu or visit ctl.wustl.edu/learningcenter to find out what support they may offer for your classes.

Center for Diversity and Inclusion (CDI)

The Center for Diversity and Inclusion (CDI) supports and advocates for undergraduate, graduate, and professional school students from underrepresented and/or marginalized populations, collaborates with campus and community partners, and promotes dialogue and social change to cultivate and foster a supportive campus climate for students of all backgrounds, cultures, and identities.

See: <https://diversityinclusion.wustl.edu/>.

Gephardt Institute

Students play an essential role in a vibrant and functioning democracy! State and local elections take place throughout the year and have a direct impact on our communities. You can register to vote, request an absentee ballot, confirm your polling location, and get Election Day reminders at <http://wustl.turbovote.org> for any of the 50 states and Washington D.C. WashU students are considered Missouri residents, and eligible student voters can register to vote in the state of Missouri or their home state.

If you are ineligible to vote, you can participate by encouraging your friends to register and vote, engaging your peers in local issues, and taking part in other civic and community engagement activities. For more resources on voting and other civic and community engagement opportunities, please visit <http://washuvotes.wustl.edu> and <http://gephardtinstitute.wustl.edu>.

University Libraries

University Libraries include [seven unique locations](#) across the Danforth Campus, but they are much more than just beautiful, quiet spaces for studying and group work. The Libraries include [librarians for every discipline on campus](#), with the expertise to work with you to develop research ideas and find the best resources to meet your needs; or you are welcome to explore our [research guides](#), tailored for each subject and available online. The Libraries hold five million items in the collection—print books, journals,

electronic resources, databases, and millions more accessible through interlibrary loan—and you can find it all at [the search on our home page](#). Additional resources for students include special collections, data services, citation help, digital publishing, and more. Visit [the Libraries website](#) for more details about these and other ways that the Libraries are here to support your academic success.

CONDITIONS OF ENROLLMENT FOR EMBA CANDIDATES

Candidates for the Executive of Master's Business Administration degree who entered in Fall 2022 or later are advised they are subject to the following degree requirements and conditions of study:

Conditions apply to ALL candidates.

1. Class attendance is mandatory for all EMBA students.

- Regardless of whether prior approval is received from a professor, a student who misses more than 25% of the class hours for a course will be considered to have missed the entire course. The student will be given a "No Grade (N)" if they do not attend 75% of the course.
- If a student misses a course, he or she is required to make up the course with the next EMBA cohort.
- Students should work with the EMBA staff to make sure they are enrolled in a make-up class. Graduation from the program will be delayed until completion of the make-up course.
- A student who misses more than two courses may be asked to begin with a new cohort.

2. All Executive MBA students are expected to attend class and be prepared for active participation at each meeting.

- If you find yourself in a situation in which absence cannot be avoided, you may watch an online recording of a St. Louis-based class session, when available, through Canvas. Class recordings are therefore simply one tool we provide to aid learning when absences are unavoidable.
- Relative to the EMBA Attendance Policy, viewing recordings of missed class sessions is not considered a substitute for or equivalent to live classroom participation. However, if you join the class session live, in the hybrid virtual format, it will be considered classroom participation, if the student's camera is turned on and the student is verbally participating with questions and comments.
- All Executive MBA program recorded material is protected under the copyright laws of the United States. Therefore, all EMBA students will sign the policy statement, which will be kept on file until you graduate, indicating your understanding that class session recordings are the intellectual property of each individual instructor and under United States copyright law may not be copied or distributed without express written permission.

3. **Students must complete all course requirements. Irrespective of the 25% attendance policy, a faculty member may decide that certain sessions cannot be missed and therefore the student must attend those sessions at a later date with a current EMBA cohort or a future EMBA cohort.**
 - Simulations in Operations and Global may be required in order to pass the course.
 - Students must seek pre-approval from professors to attend at a later date, prior to their scheduled class session.
4. **Students are expected to pay tuition on time on the pre-set dates provided. If a student does not meet the obligation, he or she will not be enrolled in the next semester. This “hold” will not be lifted until tuition is paid. If the last payment cycle is not met, the student’s graduation will be on hold.**
5. **All EMBA students are required to collaborate and work effectively in a team as each student will be assigned to a team.**
 - Effective performance in study teams is vital to success in the Executive MBA program. Failure to demonstrate effective team performance carries the same consequence as any other academic performance problem, up to and including immediate dismissal from the program. All EMBA students will be individually evaluated on their study team performance via self and peer evaluations; these results can be used by a professor as part of the grading system.
6. **Students must complete all course work. Course work that is not complete on the date that grades are recorded will receive an (I) Incomplete. After 90 days an incomplete grade is automatically changed to a (NP) No Pass unless prior arrangements have been made with the student advisor and the faculty member teaching the course.**
7. **Periodically, student academic performance is evaluated and must be maintained at a level consistent with the standards established by the Olin Business School (Olin).**
 - In the case of an NP grade, the student will be required to re-take the course or to take a pre-approved equivalent course in the MBA or PMBA program. Graduation will be delayed until completion of the make-up course.
 - Any student with an NP grade or more than three LP grades will be placed on academic probation. The case will be considered by the Academic Review Committee, and he/she will be in jeopardy of immediate academic dismissal.
 - Any student earning more than one LP grade is encouraged to meet with their academic advisor to determine the underlying cause of the low grades and to develop a plan for improving performance.
8. **Students must meet all graduation requirements and apply for graduation.**
 - Graduation Eligibility: Any student with an NP grade or with more than nine credit hours of LP grades is ineligible to graduate.
 - Graduation Distinction: The top 20% of the cohort is eligible for induction into Beta Gamma Sigma International Business Honor Society at graduation.

9. Non-EMBA Electives Do Not Count Toward EMBA Degree:

- EMBA students have access to Olin electives in the full-time MBA on a space-available basis. This benefit covers the full tuition of the course, but additional fees, parking, and textbooks are the responsibility of the student. The EMBA Registrar will facilitate the approval and registration process for both current EMBA students and EMBA alumni up to two years following graduation.
- EMBA students cannot register for courses using this benefit until 3 weeks after registration opens in order to accommodate degree-seeking MBA & PMBA students.
- All registrations must be approved by both the EMBA Registrar and the student's academic advisor. An EMBA student or graduate who earns a grade of "No Pass" or "Incomplete" in a non-EMBA elective forfeits his/her right to enroll in further non-EMBA electives until that "No Pass" or "Incomplete" grade is remediated. While elective courses do not count toward a degree, all students enrolled using this benefit are enrolled with a P/F grade option.
- EMBA students can view the elective course opportunities on WebSTAC by clicking on the courses tab, look under schools - business. Courses that are not approved for this benefit include core course requirements for the full-time MBA and PMBA students, as well as non-degree seminars and certificate programs. For additional information, contact Joe Willis, EMBA Registrar, at willis@wustl.edu.

10. All students, staff, and faculty are required to conduct themselves within the guidelines of the Olin Code of Professional Conduct and Graduate Student Academic Integrity policy detailed in the "Integrity Matters" booklet. Students are asked to read this and conduct themselves accordingly during their entire period of study. Students are also subject to the University Judicial Code (Student Conduct Code). Ignorance of the contents of the "Integrity Matters" or the University Judicial Code is not an acceptable excuse for a breach of conduct.

Rev. 8/9/24

LEADERSHIP COMMUNICATION COURSE
SPEAKING SELF-ASSESSMENT

Please respond to the questions in this speaker's self-assessment survey by **11:59 p.m., Friday, November 15, 2024**. Submit your responses on our Canvas course website.

NAME: _____

DATE: _____

TITLE/COMPANY: _____

1. Please tell me about yourself, going into as much detail as you would like. Provide a personal and demographic profile – background, interests, family, proudest accomplishments, regrets, etc. (In addition, feel free to attach your bio, if you'd like to offer more information.)
2. What three words would you use to describe yourself as a public speaker?
3. What do you consider (or have you been told by others) are your greatest strengths as a public speaker?
4. What do you consider (or have you been told by others) are the biggest challenges you face related to public speaking? What have you already tried to address these challenges?
5. Ask three people who have heard you speak in various settings (professional lectures, classes, personal special-occasion speeches such as toasts, eulogies, introductions, etc.) to share three words they feel best describe you as a public speaker. Please list them here.
6. What do you think the <i>other</i> members of your cohort need to hear or learn about public speaking and executive presence?
7. Additional Comments:

Assessment Developed by Kelly Standing, Standing Media, LLC (www.standingmedia.com)
(Used with permission.) *Rev. 0824*



Five Steps to Building Your Personal Leadership Brand

by Dave Ulrich and Norm Smallwood

See a complete list of Harvard Business School
Publishing newsletters:

<http://newsletters.harvardbusinessonline.org>

Harvard Management Update reprints and
subscriptions:

<http://hmu.harvardbusinessonline.org>
phone 1-800-988-0866 or 617-783-7500

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phone 617-783-7587

Five Steps to Building Your Personal Leadership Brand

by Dave Ulrich and Norm Smallwood

You have a personal leadership brand. But do you have the right one?

The question is not trivial. A leadership brand conveys your identity and distinctiveness as a leader. It communicates the value you offer. If you have the wrong leadership brand for the position you have or the position you want, then your work is not having the impact it could.

We use the term brand very deliberately. Acme Manufacturing can make the greatest widget in the world, but if few people know about the company or the widget—if neither has a strong brand—then that widget will generate little value. It's the same thing with leaders. A strong personal leadership brand allows all that's powerful and effective about your leadership to become known to your colleagues up, down, and across the organization, enabling you to generate maximum value.

In this article, which is adapted from our book *Leadership Brand: Developing Customer-Focused Leaders to Drive Performance and Build Lasting Value* (Harvard Business School Press, 2007), we will show you how to shape a personal leadership brand that showcases who you are and what you can do. The benefit of consciously shaping a leadership brand is focus; when you know with utmost clarity what you want to be known for, it is easier to let go of the tasks and projects that do not let you deliver on that brand and to concentrate on activities that do.

1. DETERMINE THE RESULTS YOU WANT TO ACHIEVE IN THE NEXT YEAR

The first thing you should do is ask yourself, "In the next 12 months, what are the major results I want to deliver at work?" Take into account the interests of these four groups:

- **Customers:** Identify customers who directly or indirectly receive value from the goods or services you produce. How can you add value for them?
- **Investors:** What do they want? What can you and your group do to meet their expectations?
- **Employees:** What employee outcomes do you seek: greater creativity, better collaboration, higher retention? What do your employees need from you?

- **The organization:** How can your team help the organization execute on its strategy?

We once worked with a very talented and hard-working executive we'll call Judy. Her successful performance in several varied roles at her organization—she'd been an auditor, a process engineer, and a customer-service manager—earned her a promotion into a general manager position, in which she would be running one of the company's largest businesses. To succeed at her first large-scale leadership position and meet the complex set of expectations she would encounter in it, she knew she needed to become more deliberate about the way she led others. In short, she knew she needed a new leadership brand and turned to us for help in forging it.

On our advice, she reviewed overall customer retention, satisfaction, and revenue figures and called on three of the business's largest customers to hear their thoughts on the division's strengths and opportunities for improvement. She analyzed her division's financial performance over the previous years and thoroughly reviewed the financial performance expected of it in the coming year. She met with small groups of employees and reviewed employee surveys and other data to assess how employees both inside and outside the division regarded it. Finally, she thought carefully about how her business could contribute more to the organization as a whole.

Notice that we advised Judy to begin by focusing on the expectations of those she was working to serve, rather than on what she identified as her personal strengths. Leadership brand is outward focused; it is about delivering results. While identifying innate strengths is an important part of defining your leadership brand, the starting point is clarifying what is expected of you.

2. DECIDE WHAT YOU WISH TO BE KNOWN FOR

Given the context of the business results you want to achieve, consider how you wish to be perceived. From the chart below, pick the six descriptors that best capture what you want to be known for.

Possible attributes

Accepting	Accountable	Action-oriented
Adaptable	Agile	Agreeable

Analytical	Approachable	Assertive
Attentive	Benevolent	Bold
Bright	Calm	Caring
Charismatic	Clever	Collaborative
Committed	Compassionate	Competent
Concerned	Confident	Confrontative
Conscientious	Considerate	Consistent
Creative	Curious	Decisive
Dedicated	Deliberate	Dependable
Determined	Diplomatic	Disciplined
Driven	Easygoing	Efficient
Emotional	Energetic	Enthusiastic
Even-tempered	Fast	Flexible
Focused	Forgiving	Friendly
Fun-loving	Good listener	Happy
Helpful	Honest	Hopeful
Humble	Independent	Innovative
Insightful	Inspired	Integrative
Intelligent	Intimate	Inventive
Kind	Knowledgeable	Lively
Logical	Loving	Loyal
Nurturing	Optimistic	Organized
Outgoing	Passionate	Patient
Peaceful	Pensive	Persistent
Personal	Playful	Pleasant
Polite	Positive	Pragmatic
Prepared	Proactive	Productive
Quality-oriented	Reality-based	Religious
Respectful	Responsible	Responsive
Results-oriented	Satisfied	Savvy
Self-confident	Selfless	Sensitive
Service-oriented	Sincere	Sociable
Straightforward	Thorough	Thoughtful
Tireless	Tolerant	Trusting
Trustworthy	Unyielding	Values-driven

Judy knew she was seen as technically proficient and hardworking but somewhat aloof. These traits, she realized, added up to a leadership brand that would not take her very far in her new role.

Working from our list, she picked six descriptors that balanced the qualities that came naturally to her with those that would be critical in her new position, and then she tested her choices by sharing them with her boss, her peers, and some of her most trusted subordinates. She simply asked them, “Are these the traits that someone in this general manager role should exhibit?” Their responses helped her refine her list to ultimately include:

- Collaborative
- Deliberate
- Independent

- Innovative
- Results-oriented
- Strategic

It is important to keep in mind that the list you put together may well require you to stretch yourself in new directions—that is fine. But be sure not to include in it traits that you do not believe you can ever truly exhibit. Judy, for instance, recognized that working collaboratively did not come naturally to her, but she felt it was in her power to do it effectively.

3. DEFINE YOUR IDENTITY

The next step is to combine these six words into three two-word phrases that reflect your desired identity. This exercise allows you to build a deeper, more complex description: not only what you want to be known for but also how you will probably have to act to get there. For example, calmly driven differs from tirelessly driven. Experimenting with the many combinations that you can make from your six chosen words helps you crystallize your personal leadership brand.

Judy combined the six descriptors into the following three phrases:

1. Independently innovative
2. Deliberately collaborative
3. Strategically results-oriented

This second list, which, like the first she tested with several colleagues, neatly pulled together what came easily to Judy (“independently innovative” and “strategically results-oriented”) with what she could accomplish through disciplined effort (“deliberately collaborative”). Judy was satisfied that it aptly described both the kind of leader she was and the kind of leader she was becoming.

4. CONSTRUCT YOUR LEADERSHIP BRAND STATEMENT AND TEST IT

In this step, you pull everything together in a leadership brand statement that makes a “so that” connection between what you want to be known for (Steps 2 and 3) and your desired results (Step 1). Fill in the blanks:

I want to be known for being _____ so that I can deliver _____.

Judy’s leadership brand statement read: “I want to be known for being independently innovative, deliberately collaborative, and strategically results-oriented so that I

can deliver superior financial outcomes for my business.”

With your leadership brand statement drafted, ask the following questions to see if it needs to be refined:

- *Is this the brand identity that best represents who I am and what I can do?* If you lived this declaration of leadership, would you see yourself as successful? Are you willing to tell others that this is your personal leadership brand?
- *Is this brand identity something that creates value in the eyes of my organization and key stakeholders? Is this something that is needed?*
- *What risks am I taking by exhibiting this brand?* What will the brand keep you from understanding and doing? This is an important question—it can be tempting to choose a brand identity that supports organizational values but not your own personal values and strengths. For example, in many technology-oriented firms, technical know-how is valued over salesmanship or interpersonal strengths. It would be a mistake, however, even in such an organization, to disguise yourself as a technical leader if what really drives you is something else. Acknowledging the things your personal brand keeps you from understanding and doing helps you build a team that can compensate for areas that are not your strengths and actually increases your leadership efficacy.
- *Can I live this brand?* Do you have the ability to translate the qualities you articulate in your leadership brand statement into day-to-day behavior? Can you make specific time commitments to live the leadership brand you espouse? Can you translate it into the decisions and choices you make?

After going through this exercise, Judy was satisfied that she had crafted a personal leadership brand that was appropriate for her new role and within her power to live into and make real.

5. MAKE YOUR BRAND IDENTITY REAL

Espoused but unlived brands create cynicism because they promise what they do not deliver. To ensure that the leadership brand you advertise is embodied in your day-to-day work, ask those around you. Do they see you as you wish to be seen? If you say you are flexible and approachable, do others find you so?

After Judy defined her personal leadership brand, she shared it with others. She let people know that she was evolving as a leader and invited their feedback, especially on her efforts at working collaboratively.

Six months into the job, Judy reported to us that she had achieved positive results overall. While she believed that the business could have reached some goals faster if she had relied solely on her own technical expertise in charting its course, she recognized that such success would have come at the cost of building a strong team. And a strong team it was: members identified challenges with clarity, respected one another's judgments, made hard decisions, and moved forward together.

The exercise of forging a leadership brand and the day-to-day discipline of making it real, Judy said, helped her stay focused on the most important challenges of her new role.

YOUR BRAND SHOULD EVOLVE

Your leadership brand isn't static; it should evolve in response to the different expectations you face at different times in your career. In our work, we have seen that leaders with the self-awareness and the drive to evolve their leadership brands regularly are more likely to be successful over the long term—and to enjoy the journey more. ♦

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RESOURCES

Leadership brand plays out very powerfully at the institutional level, too. Companies with strong leadership brands create deep pipelines of skilled managers and executives and often enjoy a distinct competitive edge. To learn more about organizational leadership brand, see our *Harvard Business Review* article, “Building a Leadership Brand” (July 2007, # R0707G), or our recently published book, *Leadership Brand: Developing Customer-Focused Leaders to Drive Performance and Build Lasting Value* (Harvard Business School Press, 2007).



Managing Yourself



The New Rules of Executive Presence

How leaders need to think and act now **by Sylvia Ann Hewlett**

The New Rules of Executive Presence

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From the Magazine (January–February 2024) / Reprint R2401L



Chen Wu

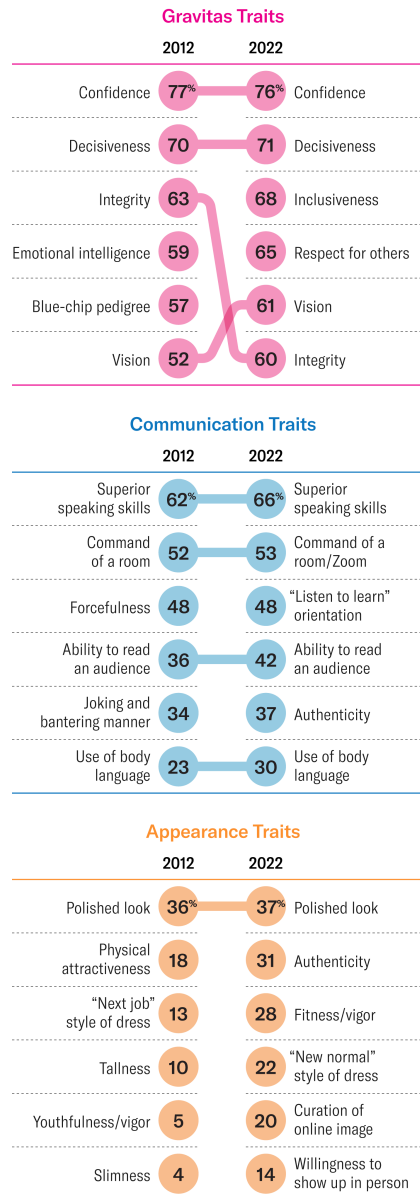
Aspiring leaders have long been told that to be considered for senior management roles, especially those in the C-suite, they must demonstrate “executive presence” (EP). In most corporate settings, that has traditionally boiled down to three attributes: gravitas, strong communication skills, and the “right” appearance. But what exactly constitutes EP now? After a decade marked by tumultuous economic, cultural, and technological change (think climate threats; the Covid-19 pandemic; war in Europe and the Middle East; the #MeToo, Black Lives Matter, and LGBTQ+ rights movements; worsening political divides; and

the rise of Zoom, Instagram, and other online platforms), how have expectations about ideal leadership traits changed?

Surveys I conducted in 2012 and in 2022 tell a story of significant shifts embedded within continuity. The 2012 survey targeted 268 U.S. business executives at the director level or above in various industries; the 2022 survey targeted 73. Both groups were asked to rank the importance of 25 leadership traits.

Redefining Executive Presence

Business leaders today, like their counterparts a decade ago, view EP as a combination of gravitas, communication skills, and appearance. However, there have been some striking changes in the specific traits in each category that survey respondents consider most important.



Note: Survey participants—268 high-level U.S. executives in 2012 and 73 in 2022—were asked to select the six most important leadership traits from a list of 25.

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Confidence and decisiveness have not gone out of style; those are still the most-sought-after traits contributing to gravitas, which accounts for the lion's share of EP. However, inclusiveness, in all its manifestations—respecting others, listening to learn, telegraphing authenticity—has shot onto the list of the most-valued components of all three dimensions of EP. That change reflects the new weight of diversity, equity, and inclusion in business strategy.

The old ideal—shaped and embodied by white male CEOs who ruled the U.S. and European corporate worlds through the beginning of this century—has long been eroding. In sharing my latest research findings here, I aim to shed light on what the preferred leadership model looks like today. Women and people of color no longer have to fit into a mold not fashioned for them. But they must still cultivate a confident, decisive, polished, and commanding persona without running afoul of biased social norms that punish them for overstepping. Meanwhile, executives who neatly match the old profile can't rest on their laurels, assuming that the EP that once afforded them power will continue to do so. They must stretch themselves in new ways to meet evolving expectations for leaders to be “real”—online as well as in person—while simultaneously ensuring that team members feel seen, heard, and valued.

What follows is a guide to the new rules of executive presence—a look at the traits that increasingly matter, some ways to cultivate them, and a dozen people who currently exemplify them.

Gravitas

Trait: Inclusiveness. To be inclusive, you must not only hire people with diverse backgrounds and give everyone a fair shot at climbing the ladder. You must also ensure that all your employees feel appreciated

and supported. In doing so, you will uncover value for individuals, your team, and your organization.

Tactic: Deliver informed empathy. When MGM Resorts International started to reopen its hotels and casinos in the winter of 2020–2021, CEO Bill Hornbuckle wanted to raise the morale of employees as they struggled to recover from the tragedies and disruptions of Covid-19. Hornbuckle had started his career as a room-service waiter at the Jockey Club, so he understood the demands on his people. He knew that MGM could improve their work experience while also setting itself up as an employer of choice as the hospitality sector ramped up and the labor market tightened. After much fact-finding and many focus groups, he and his team rolled out what they called a “culture of yes.” It was all about empowering employees to say yes to guests and authorizing managers to say yes to employees—whether they were seeking three-day workweeks, short shifts, or the ability to move from hourly work to the management track. “We’re giving them what they told us they most want—the ability to deliver excellence on the job and improve their own prospects,” Hornbuckle explained to me. “Employees now see us leaders as having more understanding and empathy.”

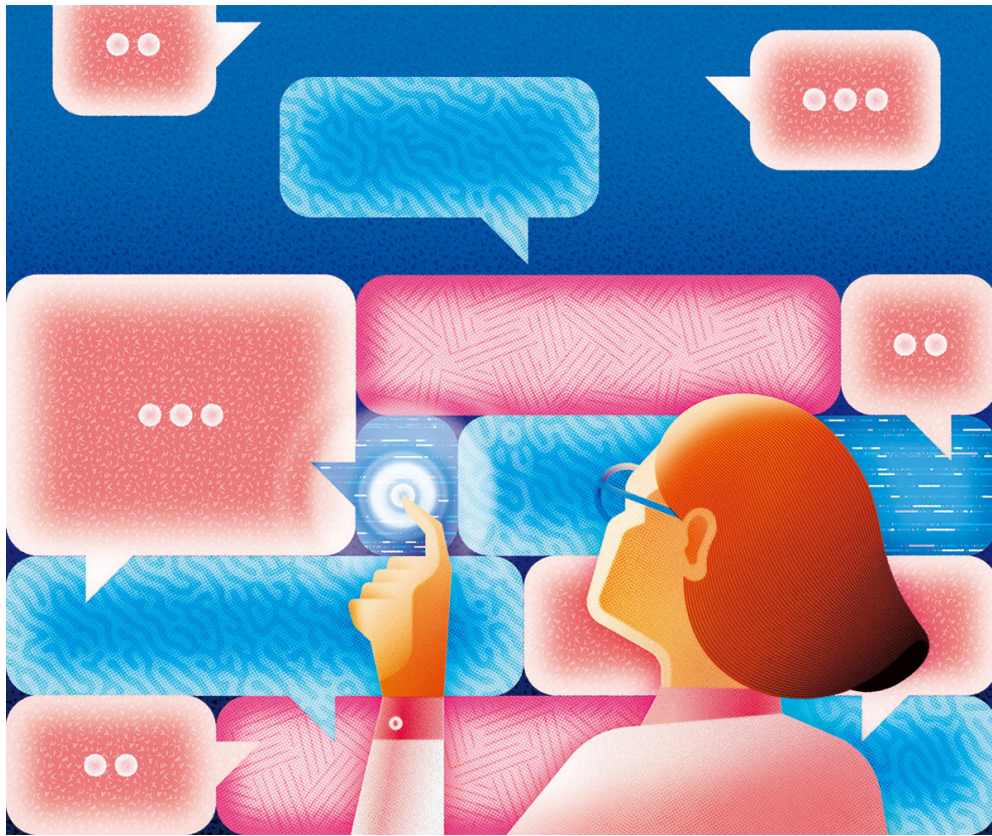
Tactic: Volunteer a “value add.” Back when he was an assistant vice president at Merrill Lynch, Todd Sears approached his mentor, managing director Subha Barry, with a business idea that focused on better serving the LGBTQ+ community. As an openly gay man, Sears knew that most wealth-management firms catered to straight people and had very few products or services tailored to the needs of people like him. For example, since same-sex couples are much less likely than heterosexual couples to have children in their households (15% compared with 38%, according to U.S. Census Bureau data), they tend to be more interested in targeted philanthropy than in college-tuition savings accounts. Furthermore, Sears’s activism on behalf of LGBTQ+

rights had made him a well-known figure in the gay community, and he was able to bring in partners eager to work with Merrill on this venture. Barry, who had none of those connections, was excited about tapping into a new market and making Merrill more inclusive. Over several years she and Sears built a team that managed more than \$2 billion in assets invested by LGBTQ+ clients.

Trait: Respect for Others. Being a respectful leader requires much more than treating everyone with dignity. It involves acquiring a body of knowledge that allows you to understand the lived experiences of those whose identity or heritage is different from your own. Consult experts, dig down into the research, and add people with diverse perspectives to your team. If you go beyond empathy and compassion, you may gain valuable insights that can strengthen your business.

Tactic: Hire and utilize diverse talent. Laura Garza, the chief people officer at Dyson, sees respect for others as vital to her company's success. The technology firm, known for its vacuums and other appliances, has made a point of hiring people who hail from different countries and have varied backgrounds. "There's a recognition here that global and diverse talent generates disruptive innovation," Garza told me. "I'm Mexican and I'm gay," she added. "That puts me in a position to 'get' the complexity of the global marketplace." She is not alone: These days half the members of Dyson's executive leadership team are women, 60% grew up outside Britain (where the company started), and all agree that having a multinational, multiethnic workforce has spurred the development of some extremely successful products. Take hair dryers. In China and Japan, women typically wash their hair at night and use hair-care rituals to "wind down." They're looking for serenity. In sharp contrast, most British and American women wash their hair in the morning, when they're racing to get to work or drop the kids off at school. They're looking for speed. Dyson's Supersonic hair

dryer was developed to serve both customer segments. It has become a bestseller in Asia because it's quiet and safe, with no blades or brushes, and in Europe and the United States because it's the lightest and fastest dryer on the market. This smash success has contributed significantly to growth at Dyson: Company revenue surged exponentially in the first half of 2023.



Chen Wu

Tactic: Look beyond the pedigree. As the CEO of IBM from 2012 to 2020, Ginni Rometty committed to a suite of policies and practices designed to give a leg up to young people from less-advantaged backgrounds, helping them finish high school, earn two-year associate degrees in a STEM field, and find well-paid jobs at IBM and elsewhere. Part of the inspiration for developing these “new-collar” workers was

Rometty's mom, who with four children and no education past high school had to figure out how to earn a living when her husband, Rometty's dad, abandoned their family. It was tough going. "She wasn't dumb; she just didn't have access," Rometty says. "And that has forever stayed in my mind." Her efforts at IBM paid off. In 2020 new-collar workers constituted 15% of the company's U.S. hires. They've helped IBM weather labor shortages and successfully transition to new technologies. This tranche of talent has also proved to be more loyal and more eager to stay at the company than recruits from elite four-year schools.

Communication

Trait: Command of Zoom. Covid-19 sped up the shift to virtual communication, and many of the executives I interviewed in 2022 told me that they struggled to master the art of leading on Zoom, Teams, Slack, and other online platforms. But doing so is key to EP today.

Tactic: Ace the visuals. The late Apple cofounder and CEO Steve Jobs had legendary command of what he called "the visuals." This was the not-so-secret sauce that allowed him to inspire his engineers and stir the souls of millions of new tech users, whether he showed up in person or via video. He accomplished this by eliminating the superfluous: His speaking style was crisp, clear, and concise; he used blank backdrops; and he wore minimalist outfits that signaled edgy elegance but weren't distracting. Most importantly, he dispensed with notes, lecterns, teleprompters, and PowerPoints, focusing instead on eye contact. Whether face-to-face or on camera, Jobs always looked directly into a person's eyes. His visuals carried particular weight because they were grounded in the clean aesthetics and Zen values that were fundamental to who he was and what his company stood for.

Tactic: Proactively manage virtual meetings. As the chief financial officer of Reginn, an Icelandic real estate firm with clients around the world, Rosa Gudmundsdottir has become a whiz at staging high-impact virtual meetings. She follows a few simple rules. First, she oversees a brief tech check beforehand to ensure no snafus. Second, she distributes an agenda and relevant pre-reads at least six hours in advance. Third, she starts meetings by introducing anyone new to the group, taking care to highlight a skill set or an experience that the person brings to the topic at hand. Fourth, during the meeting she solicits participation from everyone in attendance, encouraging those who've been quiet to share their thoughts on a key question. Finally, at the end of the meeting she asks a colleague to write and quickly distribute a summary of decisions made and next steps. She rotates this job so that her entire team gets a turn.

Trait: “Listen to Learn” Orientation. Although displaying forcefulness was high on the list of most-sought-after communication traits in 2012, it's less desired today. People now gravitate more toward leaders who listen and learn from others before they make decisions—a trait seen as critical to growing markets and retaining top talent.

Tactic: Engage eye-to-eye. When Jørgen Vig Knudstorp took the helm of Lego, the company was struggling. His theory was that it had strayed too far from its core mission by diversifying into Lego-branded clothing, theme parks, jewelry, and video games, but as a new chief executive coming in from the outside, he wanted to test that hypothesis before acting on it. Over a 12-month period he sat down with every category of employee at Lego—engineers in the design shop, workers on the factory floor, executives in the C-suite—seeking information and guidance. He also met up with external stakeholders, including customers, retailers, and specialists in early childhood education. He even spent three days at a Lego conference for adult fans in Washington, DC, mingling with

attendees and paying attention to their concerns. This listening journey uncovered a groundswell of support for Lego to refocus on its signature building blocks, which are designed to nurture children's problem-solving abilities and creativity. Knudstorp subsequently embedded listening "up close and personal" in the company culture. For example, every year Lego involves thousands of its customers as "volunteer designers" to advise on product updates. This ongoing consultative process is a large part of why the company is back on a growth path.

Tactic: Go beyond your comfort zone. Unilever, which makes and markets hundreds of consumer goods in 190 countries, takes listening seriously, asking selected current and future leaders to spend time outside the realm of their normal experiences in a program called GITS (Get Inside the Skin). GITS is designed to teach them how to better empathize with the company's 3 billion customers, who come from all walks of life. Former chairman and CEO Niall FitzGerald helped create GITS and was also a participant, volunteering for the Salvation Army in Croatia, where he interacted with the homeless. He describes meeting one "unkempt, uncared-for man" who happened to be from his own hometown back in Ireland. "We were two people to whom fate had dealt very different hands," FitzGerald recalls. "He taught me, in a way no other experience has, the power of generous listening—without judgment." Other Unilever employees have spent time at a rural hospital in Mexico, an AIDS clinic in Ireland, and a prison in Germany. Like FitzGerald, those leaders are working hard to better understand all their customers.

Appearance

Trait: Authenticity. Appearance is the least-important EP bucket, but it's the one that changed most from 2012 to 2022. Authenticity, which didn't register with survey respondents 10 years ago, is newly prized. Nowadays, to be seen as leadership material, executives are expected to

reveal who they fundamentally are—not mimic some dated, idealized model.

Tactic: Showcase your roots and values. Throughout her long career in the U.S. finance industry—from intern at Fannie Mae to senior roles at JPMorgan Chase to CEO of TIAA—Thasunda Brown Duckett has shown up as exactly who she is: a Black woman who experienced both racism and economic uncertainty growing up in Texas with a blue-collar dad and teacher mom. Because she understood her parents’ powerful aspirations for homeownership, she was drawn to the mortgage and lending business, and she now leads an organization that offers investment, retirement, and banking advice to people in the caring sector (teaching, government service, health care, and the nonprofit world). She has always been clear about her background and values and offered several examples in a 2019 interview with the *New York Times*: the time she told a client that she had no intention of hunting or fishing with him but would happily go out for sushi; the conversation in which she accepted a big promotion only after reminding her boss that she was pregnant and would be taking a three-month maternity leave; her supportive response to an African American team member who wanted advice on styling her hair for a big presentation (Duckett, who is herself often in long braids, asked, “What would make you feel beautiful?”); and the way she kicked off an hourlong conversation with her coworkers about race, saying, “I’m an angry Black woman today” and explaining that her son had been called a derogatory name at school. As she told the *Times*, “I just bring the best version of Thasunda, all of me, to the table, because I want everyone else to do the same.”

Tactic: Dress for the new normal. Figuring out what to wear in today’s hybrid workplace is challenging for both seasoned and emerging leaders. Most white-collar professionals who worked remotely during the pandemic adopted casual, comfortable attire. However, “polished”

still reigns as the most-sought-after appearance trait. One executive who seems to have a good handle on the new dress code is Alphabet and Google CEO Sundar Pichai. Silicon Valley types are well-known for dressing down, but Pichai sets himself apart with an approachable yet professional style that people in various industries can emulate. Often pairing a black leather bomber jacket or a track jacket with dark jeans, a T-shirt, and high-end sneakers, even for interviews and presentations, he telegraphs a seamless interweaving of work and personal life. He's also savvy enough to adapt his attire for different settings, signaling that he's an aware global citizen who can bridge divides. For example, to testify before the U.S. Congress, he has worn tailored suits to fit in with the legislators questioning him. But when he met with Indonesian president Joko Widodo, he donned a shirt with an earth-toned print that resembled Southeast Asian ikat patterns—a gesture that was reportedly well received by the local audience.

Trait: Online and In-Person Presence. Being a standout leader in 2024 necessitates showing up both online and in the flesh.

Tactic: Use social media to shape your brand. Sheryl Sandberg isn't leaving the vital matter of her legacy in the hands of biographers and historians; she's shaping it herself. She wants to be thought of as the best-selling author of *Lean In*—someone who coached women on how to own ambition and shoot for the stars—rather than remembered as the hard-nosed businesswoman who spent 14 years growing and protecting Facebook. So since stepping down from the COO role at Meta in June of 2022, she has been using her social media presence to focus on women who have leaned in. Her recent Instagram posts, for example, celebrate the achievements of female business owners: a Black entrepreneur who runs a wildly successful dessert company in Tulsa, Oklahoma; a Lebanese restaurateur who's opened a chic café in Montreal that has become a go-to place and highly profitable.

Tactic: Build relationships in person. Tiger Tyagarajan, the CEO of Genpact, a 115,000-person business services company, is much admired for his success empowering high-performing women. Between 2011 and 2023 he shifted the percentage of women in senior roles from 1% to 38%. In 2022, as the pandemic quieted down, he noticed that men were more willing than women to come back to the office. He didn't want to force everyone to return, but he worried that women who stayed fully remote might imperil their promotion prospects by being "out of sight, out of mind." Therefore, he began having executives pull their teams together every six weeks for two-day on-site retreats. "We meet in Genpact offices, stay in local hotels, and break bread together as well as dig down into next-gen challenges and opportunities," he told me. "Extraordinary exhilaration and energy come out of these office retreats, plus a host of new ideas, and on the relationship-building front, they're a game changer. They go a long way toward leveling the playing field for women who work from home."

...

"The new rules of EP are both daunting and exhilarating," says Kennedy Ihezie, a rising star at the insurance giant AIG. To show confidence and decisiveness but also inclusiveness and respect, to balance powerful speaking and a commanding presence with listening and learning, and to project both polish and authenticity is a heavy lift. But leaders who manage it can inspire their employees to greater achievements and help their organizations truly flourish.

Given the high stakes, I want to offer an important piece of encouragement. My research in both 2012 and 2022 indicates that executive presence is learnable. You don't have to be some kind of genius to crack the EP code—you must simply act, speak, and appear in ways that set you apart as a leader. That starts with knowing what behaviors are most valued in your organization and industry,

seeking guidance from sponsors, and then committing to the hard work of embodying and displaying those traits in your own unique way. Remember, too, that you don't have to nail every prized leadership trait in the gravitas, communication, and appearance buckets. Ginni Rometty doesn't sweep the board, nor does Sundar Pichai. Success can come from simply developing your authentic strengths and excelling at two or three competencies in each EP category. But please, make sure to focus on at least one leadership trait that's in ascendance.

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MANAGING YOURSELF

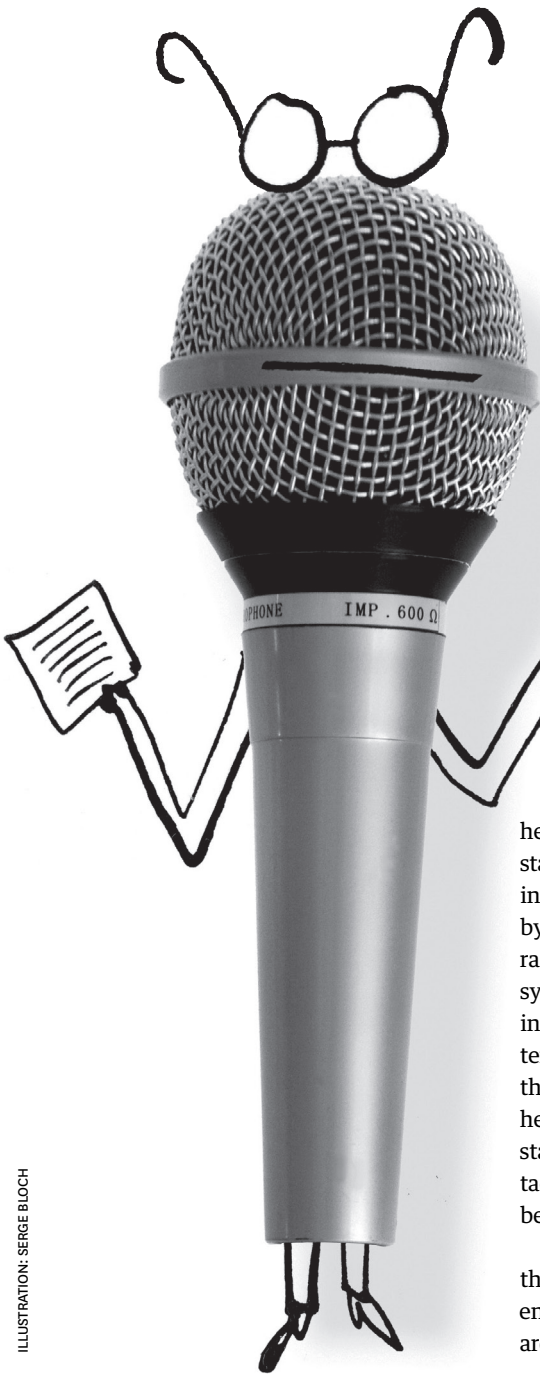
How to Give a Killer Presentation

Lessons from TED *by Chris Anderson*

MANAGING YOURSELF

How to Give a Killer Presentation

Lessons from TED *by Chris Anderson*



A little more than a year ago, on a trip to Nairobi, Kenya, some colleagues and I met a 12-year-old Masai boy named Richard Turere, who told us a fascinating story. His family raises livestock on the edge of a vast national park, and one of the biggest challenges is protecting the animals from lions—especially at night. Richard had noticed that placing lamps in a field didn't deter lion attacks, but when he walked the field with a torch, the lions stayed away. From a young age, he'd been interested in electronics, teaching himself by, for example, taking apart his parents' radio. He used that experience to devise a system of lights that would turn on and off in sequence—using solar panels, a car battery, and a motorcycle indicator box—and thereby create a sense of movement that he hoped would scare off the lions. He installed the lights, and the lions stopped attacking. Soon villages elsewhere in Kenya began installing Richard's "lion lights."

The story was inspiring and worthy of the broader audience that our TED conference could offer, but on the surface, Richard seemed an unlikely candidate to give a

TED Talk. He was painfully shy. His English was halting. When he tried to describe his invention, the sentences tumbled out incoherently. And frankly, it was hard to imagine a preteenager standing on a stage in front of 1,400 people accustomed to hearing from polished speakers such as Bill Gates, Sir Ken Robinson, and Jill Bolte Taylor.

But Richard's story was so compelling that we invited him to speak. In the months before the 2013 conference, we worked with him to frame his story—to find the right place to begin, and to develop a succinct and logical arc of events. On the back of his invention Richard had won a scholarship to one of Kenya's best schools, and there he had the chance to practice the talk several times in front of a live audience. It was critical that he build his confidence to the point where his personality could shine through. When he finally gave his talk at TED, in Long Beach, you could tell he was nervous, but that only made him more engaging—people were hanging on his every word. The confidence was there, and every time Richard smiled, the audience melted. When he finished, the response was instantaneous: a sustained standing ovation.

Since the first TED conference, 30 years ago, speakers have run the gamut from political figures, musicians, and TV personalities who are completely at ease before a crowd to lesser-known academics, scientists, and writers—some of whom feel deeply uncomfortable giving presentations. Over the years, we’ve sought to develop a process for helping inexperienced presenters to frame, practice, and deliver talks that people enjoy watching. It typically begins six to nine months before the event, and involves cycles of devising (and revising) a script, repeated rehearsals, and plenty of fine-tuning. We’re continually tweaking our approach—because the art of public speaking is evolving in real time—but judging by public response, our basic regimen works well: Since we began putting TED Talks online, in 2006, they’ve been viewed more than one billion times.

On the basis of this experience, I’m convinced that giving a good talk is highly coachable. In a matter of hours, a speaker’s content and delivery can be transformed from muddled to mesmerizing. And while my team’s experience has focused on TED’s 18-minutes-or-shorter format, the lessons we’ve learned are surely useful to other presenters—whether it’s a CEO doing an IPO road show, a brand manager unveiling a new product, or a start-up pitching to VCs.

Frame Your Story

There’s no way you can give a good talk unless you have something worth talking about. Conceptualizing and framing what you want to say is the most vital part of preparation.

We all know that humans are wired to listen to stories, and metaphors abound for the narrative structures that work best to engage people. When I think about compelling presentations, I think about taking an audience on a journey. A successful talk is a little miracle—people see the world differently afterward.

If you frame the talk as a journey, the biggest decisions are figuring out where

to start and where to end. To find the right place to start, consider what people in the audience already know about your subject—and how much they care about it. If you assume they have more knowledge or interest than they do, or if you start using jargon or get too technical, you’ll lose them. The most engaging speakers do a superb job of very quickly introducing the topic, explaining why they care so deeply about it, and convincing the audience members that they should, too.

The biggest problem I see in first drafts of presentations is that they try to cover

A successful talk is a little miracle—people see the world differently afterward.

too much ground. You can’t summarize an entire career in a single talk. If you try to cram in everything you know, you won’t have time to include key details, and your talk will disappear into abstract language that may make sense if your listeners are familiar with the subject matter but will be completely opaque if they’re new to it. You need specific examples to flesh out your ideas. So limit the scope of your talk to that which can be explained, and brought to life with examples, in the available time. Much of the early feedback we give aims to correct the impulse to sweep too broadly. Instead, go deeper. Give more detail. Don’t tell us about your entire field of study—tell us about your unique contribution.

Of course, it can be just as damaging to overexplain or painstakingly draw out the implications of a talk. And there the remedy is different: Remember that the people in the audience are intelligent. Let them figure some things out for themselves. Let them draw their own conclusions.

Many of the best talks have a narrative structure that loosely follows a detective story. The speaker starts out by presenting a problem and then describes the search

for a solution. There’s an “aha” moment, and the audience’s perspective shifts in a meaningful way.

If a talk fails, it’s almost always because the speaker didn’t frame it correctly, misjudged the audience’s level of interest, or neglected to tell a story. Even if the topic is important, random pontification without narrative is always deeply unsatisfying. There’s no progression, and you don’t feel that you’re learning.

I was at an energy conference recently where two people—a city mayor and a former governor—gave back-to-back talks. The mayor’s talk was essentially a list of impressive projects his city had undertaken. It came off as boasting, like a report card or an advertisement for his reelection. It quickly got boring. When the governor spoke, she didn’t list achievements; instead, she shared an idea. Yes, she recounted anecdotes from her time in office, but the idea was central—and the stories explanatory or illustrative (and also funny). It was so much more interesting. The mayor’s underlying point seemed to be how great he was, while the governor’s message was “Here’s a compelling idea that would benefit us all.”

As a general rule, people are not very interested in talks about organizations or institutions (unless they’re members of them). Ideas and stories fascinate us; organizations bore us—they’re much harder to relate to. (Businesspeople especially take note: Don’t boast about your company; rather, tell us about the problem you’re solving.)

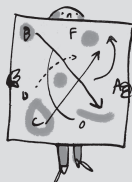
Plan Your Delivery

Once you’ve got the framing down, it’s time to focus on your delivery. There are three main ways to deliver a talk. You can read it directly off a script or a teleprompter. You can develop a set of bullet points that map out what you’re going to say in each section rather than scripting the whole thing word for word. Or you can memorize your talk, which entails rehearsing it to the point where you internalize every word—verbatim.

Find the Perfect Mix of Data and Narrative *by Nancy Duarte*

Report

Literal,
Informational,
Factual,
Exhaustive



Most presentations lie somewhere on the continuum between a report and a story. A report is data-rich, exhaustive, and informative—but not very engaging. Stories help a speaker connect with an audience, but listeners often want facts and information, too. Great presenters layer story and information like a cake, and understand that different types of talks require differing ingredients.

Story

Dramatic,
Experiential,
Evocative,
Persuasive



Research Findings

If your goal is to communicate information from a written report, send the full document to the audience in advance, and limit the presentation to key takeaways. Don't do a long slide show that repeats all your findings. Anyone who's really interested can read the report; everyone else will appreciate brevity.

Financial Presentation

Financial audiences love data, and they'll want the details. Satisfy their analytical appetite with facts, but add a thread of narrative to appeal to their emotional side. Then present the key takeaways visually, to help them find meaning in the numbers.

Product Launch

Instead of covering only specs and features, focus on the value your product brings to the world. Tell stories that show how real people will use it and why it will change their lives.

VC Pitch

For 30 minutes with a VC, prepare a crisp, well-structured story arc that conveys your idea compellingly in 10 minutes or less; then let Q&A drive the rest of the meeting. Anticipate questions and rehearse clear and concise answers.

Keynote Address

Formal talks at big events are high-stakes, high-impact opportunities to take your listeners on a transformative journey. Use a clear story framework and aim to engage them emotionally.



Nancy Duarte is the author of *HBR Guide to Persuasive Presentations*, *Slide:ology*, and *Resonate*. She is the CEO of Duarte, Inc., which designs presentations and teaches presentation development.

My advice: Don't read it, and don't use a teleprompter. It's usually just too distancing—people will know you're reading. And as soon as they sense it, the way they receive your talk will shift. Suddenly your intimate connection evaporates, and everything feels a lot more formal. We generally outlaw reading approaches of any kind at TED, though we made an exception a few years ago for a man who insisted on using a monitor. We set up a screen at the back of the auditorium, in the hope that the audience wouldn't notice it. At first he spoke naturally. But soon he stiffened up, and you could see this horrible sinking feeling pass through the audience as people realized, "Oh, no, he's reading to us!" The words were great, but the talk got poor ratings.

Many of our best and most popular TED Talks have been memorized word for word. If you're giving an important talk and you have the time to do this, it's the best way to go. But don't underestimate the work involved. One of our most memorable speakers was Jill Bolte Taylor, a brain researcher who had suffered a stroke. She talked about what she learned during

the eight years it took her to recover. After crafting her story and undertaking many hours of solo practice, she rehearsed her talk dozens of times in front of an audience to be sure she had it down.

Obviously, not every presentation is worth that kind of investment of time. But if you do decide to memorize your talk, be aware that there's a predictable arc to the learning curve. Most people go through what I call the "valley of awkwardness," where they haven't quite memorized the talk. If they give the talk while stuck in that valley, the audience will sense it. Their words will sound recited, or there will be painful moments where they stare into the middle distance, or cast their eyes upward, as they struggle to remember their lines. This creates distance between the speaker and the audience.

Getting past this point is simple, fortunately. It's just a matter of rehearsing enough times that the flow of words becomes second nature. Then you can focus on delivering the talk with meaning and authenticity. Don't worry—you'll get there.

But if you don't have time to learn a speech thoroughly and get past that awkward valley, don't try. Go with bullet points on note cards. As long as you know what you want to say for each one, you'll be fine. Focus on remembering the transitions from one bullet point to the next.

Also pay attention to your tone. Some speakers may want to come across as authoritative or wise or powerful or passionate, but it's usually much better to just sound conversational. Don't force it. Don't orate. Just be you.

If a successful talk is a journey, make sure you don't start to annoy your travel companions along the way. Some speakers project too much ego. They sound condescending or full of themselves, and the audience shuts down. Don't let that happen.

Develop Stage Presence

For inexperienced speakers, the physical act of being onstage can be the most difficult part of giving a presentation—but people tend to overestimate its importance. Getting the words, story, and substance right is a much bigger determinant

of success or failure than how you stand or whether you're visibly nervous. And when it comes to stage presence, a little coaching can go a long way.

The biggest mistake we see in early rehearsals is that people move their bodies too much. They sway from side to side, or shift their weight from one leg to the other. People do this naturally when they're nervous, but it's distracting and makes the speaker seem weak. Simply getting a person to keep his or her lower body motionless can dramatically improve stage presence. There are some people who are able to walk around a stage during a presentation, and that's fine if it comes naturally. But the vast majority are better off standing still and relying on hand gestures for emphasis.

Perhaps the most important physical act onstage is making eye contact. Find five or six friendly-looking people in different parts of the audience and look them in the eye as you speak. Think of them as friends you haven't seen in a year, whom you're bringing up to date on your work. That eye contact is incredibly powerful, and it will do more than anything else to help your talk land. Even if you don't have time to prepare fully and have to read from a script, looking up and making eye contact will make a huge difference.

Another big hurdle for inexperienced speakers is nervousness—both in advance of the talk and while they're onstage. People deal with this in different ways. Many speakers stay out in the audience until the moment they go on; this can work well, because keeping your mind engaged in the earlier speakers can distract you and limit nervousness. Amy Cuddy, a Harvard Business School professor who studies how certain body poses can affect power, utilized one of the more unusual preparation techniques I've seen. She recommends that people spend time before a talk striding around, standing tall, and extending their bodies; these poses make you feel more powerful. It's what she did before going onstage, and she delivered a phenomenal talk. But I think the single

best advice is simply to breathe deeply before you go onstage. It works.

In general, people worry too much about nervousness. Nerves are not a disaster. The audience *expects* you to be nervous. It's a natural body response that can actually improve your performance: It gives you energy to perform and keeps your mind sharp. Just keep breathing, and you'll be fine.

Acknowledging nervousness can also create engagement. Showing your vulnerability, whether through nerves or tone of voice, is one of the most powerful ways to win over an audience, provided it is authentic. Susan Cain, who wrote a book about introverts and spoke at our 2012 conference, was terrified about giving her talk. You could feel her fragility onstage, and it created this dynamic where the audience was rooting for her—everybody wanted to hug her afterward. The fact that we knew she was fighting to keep herself up there made it beautiful, and it was the most popular talk that year.

Nerves are not a disaster. The audience expects you to be nervous.

Plan the Multimedia

With so much technology at our disposal, it may feel almost mandatory to use, at a minimum, presentation slides. By now most people have heard the advice about PowerPoint: Keep it simple; don't use a slide deck as a substitute for notes (by, say, listing the bullet points you'll discuss—those are best put on note cards); and don't repeat out loud words that are on the slide. Not only is reciting slides a variation of the teleprompter problem—"Oh, no, she's reading to us, too!"—but information is interesting only once, and hearing and seeing the same words feels repetitive. That advice may seem universal by now, but go into any company and you'll see presenters violating it every day.

Many of the best TED speakers don't use slides at all, and many talks don't require them. If you have photographs or illustrations that make the topic come alive, then yes, show them. If not, consider doing without, at least for some parts of the presentation. And if you're going to use slides, it's worth exploring alternatives to PowerPoint. For instance, TED has invested in the company Prezi, which makes presentation software that offers a camera's-eye view of a two-dimensional landscape. Instead of a flat sequence of images, you can move around the landscape and zoom in to it if need be. Used properly, such techniques can dramatically boost the visual punch of a talk and enhance its meaning.

Artists, architects, photographers, and designers have the best opportunity to use visuals. Slides can help frame and pace a talk and help speakers avoid getting lost in jargon or overly intellectual language. (Art can be hard to talk about—better to experience it visually.) I've seen great presentations in which the artist or designer put slides on an automatic timer so that the image changed every 15 seconds. I've also seen presenters give a talk accompanied by video, speaking along to it. That can help sustain momentum. The industrial designer Ross Lovegrove's highly visual TED Talk, for instance, used this technique to bring the audience along on a remarkable creative journey.

Another approach creative types might consider is to build silence into their talks, and just let the work speak for itself. The kinetic sculptor Reuben Margolin used that approach to powerful effect. The idea is not to think "I'm giving a talk." Instead, think "I want to give this audience a powerful experience of my work." The single worst thing artists and architects can do is to retreat into abstract or conceptual language.

Video has obvious uses for many speakers. In a TED Talk about the intelligence of crows, for instance, the scientist showed a clip of a crow bending a hook to fish a piece of food out of a tube—essentially

10 Ways to Ruin a Presentation

creating a tool. It illustrated his point far better than anything he could have said.

Used well, video can be very effective, but there are common mistakes that should be avoided. A clip needs to be short—if it's more than 60 seconds, you risk losing people. Don't use videos—particularly corporate ones—that sound self-promotional or like infomercials; people are conditioned to tune those out. Anything with a soundtrack can be dangerously off-putting. And whatever you do, don't show a clip of yourself being interviewed on, say, CNN. I've seen speakers do this, and it's a really bad idea—no one wants to go along with you on your ego trip. The people in your audience are already listening to you live; why would they want to simultaneously watch your talking-head clip on a screen?

Putting It Together

We start helping speakers prepare their talks six months (or more) in advance so that they'll have plenty of time to practice. We want people's talks to be in final form at least a month before the event. The more practice they can do in the final weeks, the better off they'll be. Ideally, they'll practice the talk on their own and in front of an audience.

The tricky part about rehearsing a presentation in front of other people is that they will feel obligated to offer feedback and constructive criticism. Often the feedback from different people will vary or directly conflict. This can be confusing or even paralyzing, which is why it's important to be choosy about the people you use as a test audience, and whom you invite to offer feedback. In general, the more experience a person has as a presenter, the better the criticism he or she can offer.

I learned many of these lessons myself in 2011. My colleague Bruno Giussani, who curates our TEDGlobal event, pointed out that although I'd worked at TED for nine years, served as the emcee at our conferences, and introduced many of the speakers, I'd never actually given a TED

As hard as it may be to give a great talk, it's really easy to blow it. Here are some common mistakes that TED advises its speakers to avoid.

- 1** Take a really long time to explain what your talk is about.
- 2** Speak slowly and dramatically. Why talk when you can orate?
- 3** Make sure you subtly let everyone know how important you are.
- 4** Refer to your book repeatedly. Even better, quote yourself from it.
- 5** Cram your slides with numerous text bullet points and multiple fonts.
- 6** Use lots of unexplained technical jargon to make yourself sound smart.
- 7** Speak at great length about the history of your organization and its glorious achievements.
- 8** Don't bother rehearsing to check how long your talk is running.
- 9** Sound as if you're reciting your talk from memory.
- 10** Never, ever make eye contact with anyone in the audience.

Talk myself. So he invited me to give one, and I accepted.

It was more stressful than I'd expected. Even though I spend time helping others frame their stories, framing my own in a way that felt compelling was difficult. I decided to memorize my presentation, which was about how web video powers global innovation, and that was really hard: Even though I was putting in a lot of hours, and getting sound advice from my colleagues, I definitely hit a point where I didn't quite have it down and began to doubt I ever would. I really thought I might bomb. I was nervous right up until the moment I took the stage. But it ended up going fine. It's definitely not one of the all-time great TED Talks, but it got a positive reaction—and I survived the stress of going through it.

Ultimately I learned firsthand what our speakers have been discovering for three decades: Presentations rise or fall on the quality of the idea, the narrative, and the passion of the speaker. It's about substance, not speaking style or multimedia pyrotechnics. It's fairly easy to "coach out" the problems in a talk, but there's no way to "coach in" the basic story—the presenter has to have the raw material. If you have something to say, you can build a great talk. But if the central theme isn't there, you're better off not speaking. Decline the invitation. Go back to work, and wait until you have a compelling idea that's really worth sharing.

The single most important thing to remember is that there is no one good way to do a talk. The most memorable talks offer something fresh, something no one has seen before. The worst ones are those that feel formulaic. So do not on any account try to emulate every piece of advice I've offered here. Take the bulk of it on board, sure. But make the talk your own. You know what's distinctive about you and your idea. Play to your strengths and give a talk that is truly authentic to you. ♥

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Chris Anderson is the curator of TED.

INDIVIDUAL PRESENTATION FEEDBACK

PRESENTER'S NAME:
EVALUATOR:

CONTENT, STRUCTURE, ORGANIZATION	
Clear introduction of self, topic, expertise	
Easy-to-follow central idea; "road map"	
Well-supported premise, conclusions	
Smooth, logical transitions	
Appropriate, effective visuals	
DELIVERY	
Effective volume, pace, vocal variety	
Clear diction, enunciation, lack of fillers	
Evident passion, credibility for topic	
Confident poise, posture, attire, grooming	
Effective eye contact, gestures	
AUDIENCE CONNECTION AND IMPACT	
Compelling introduction captures attention	
Content relevant, interesting to audience	
Excellent storytelling	
Compelling call to action	
COMMENTS AND RECOMMENDATIONS	



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ARTICLE MANAGING PEOPLE

Begin with Trust

The first step to becoming a genuinely empowering leader
by Frances Frei and Anne Morriss



MANAGING
PEOPLE



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BEGIN

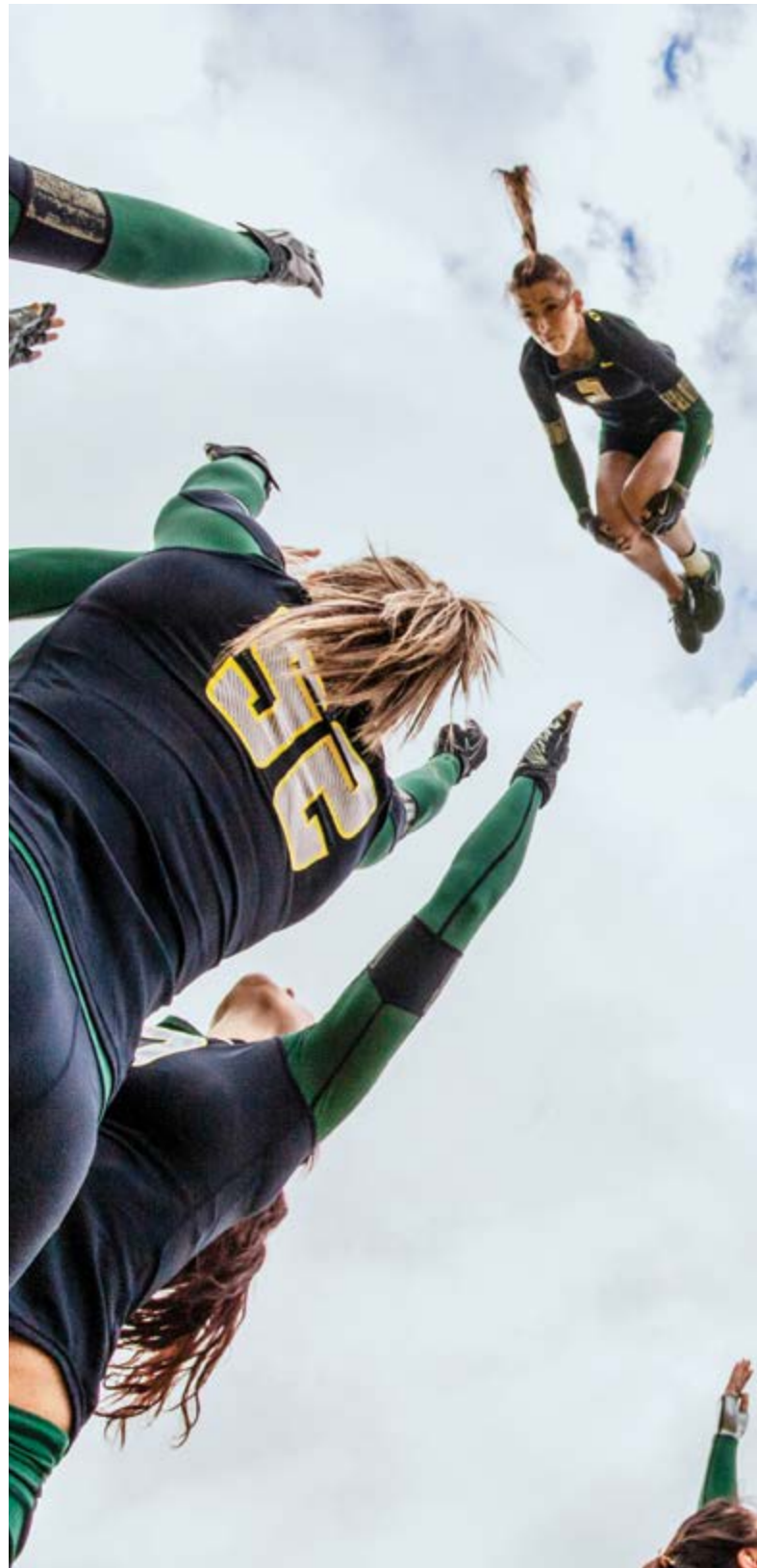
WITH

TRUST

The first step to
becoming a genuinely
empowering leader



PHOTOGRAPHER HOLLY ANDRES





IDEA IN BRIEF

THE STARTING POINT

The traditional leadership narrative is all about you: your talents, charisma, and moments of courage and instinct. But real leadership is about your people and creating the conditions for them to fully realize their own capacity and power. To do this, you have to develop stores of trust.

THE CHALLENGE

How do leaders build trust? By focusing on its core drivers: authenticity, logic, and empathy. People tend to trust you when they think they're interacting with the real you, when they have faith in your judgment and competence, and when they believe you care about them.

THE WAY FORWARD

When leaders have trouble with trust, it's usually because they're weak on one of those three drivers. To develop or restore trust, identify which driver you're "wobbly" on, and then work on strengthening it.



On a spring afternoon in 2017, Travis Kalanick, then the CEO of Uber, walked into a conference room at the company's Bay Area headquarters. One of us, Frances, was waiting for him. Meghan Joyce, the company's general manager for the United States and Canada, had reached out to us, hoping that we could guide the company as it sought to heal from a series of deep, self-inflicted wounds. We had a track record of helping organizations, many of them founder-led, tackle messy leadership and culture challenges.

MANAGING
PEOPLE

We were skeptical about Uber. Everything we'd read about the company suggested it had little hope of redemption. At the time, the company was an astonishingly disruptive and successful start-up, but its success seemed to have come at the price of basic decency. In early 2017, for example, when taxi drivers went on strike in New York City to protest President Trump's travel ban, Uber appeared to have used tactics to profit from the situation—a move that prompted widespread outrage and a #deleteUber campaign. A month later, not long before the meeting, an Uber engineer named Susan Fowler had blogged courageously about her experiences of harassment and discrimination at the company, which caused more outrage. Footage of Kalanick had then emerged, in a video that went viral, of his interaction with an Uber driver, where he appeared dismissive of the pain of earning a living in a post-Uber world. Additional charges leveled at the company in this period reinforced Uber's reputation as a cold-blooded operator that would do almost anything to win.

Despite our skepticism, Frances had gone to California to hear Kalanick out. (Anne was building her own company at the time, so she took a back seat on the project.) As Frances waited for him to make his entrance, she braced herself for the smug CEO she'd read about. But that wasn't who walked in. Kalanick arrived humbled and introspective. He had thought a lot about how the cultural values he'd instilled in the company—the very values that had fueled Uber's success—had also been misused and distorted on his watch. He expressed deep respect for what his team had achieved but also acknowledged that he'd put some people in leadership roles without giving them the training or mentorship to be effective. Whatever mistakes Kalanick had made up to that point, he revealed a sincere desire to do the right thing as a leader.

We regrouped back in Cambridge, Massachusetts, and debated whether to take on the project. There were lots of reasons to stay far away from it. The work would be hard and its outcome uncertain, to say nothing of the brutal commute. Uber's workforce was frustrated, and the brand was becoming toxic. But we realized that if we could help get Uber back on the right path, then we could offer a road map to countless others trying to restore humanity to organizations that had lost their way. So we signed on.

After making that decision, we knew exactly where to start. With trust.

EMPOWERMENT LEADERSHIP

We think of trust as precious, and yet it's the basis for almost everything we do as civilized people. Trust is the reason we're willing to exchange our hard-earned paychecks for goods and services, pledge our lives to another person in marriage, cast a ballot for someone who will represent our interests. We rely on laws and contracts as safety nets, but even they are ultimately built on trust in the institutions that enforce them. We don't know that justice will be served if something goes wrong, but we have enough faith in the system that we're willing to make high-stakes deals with relative strangers.

Trust is also one of the most essential forms of capital a leader has. Building trust, however, often requires thinking about leadership from a new perspective. The traditional leadership narrative is all about you: your vision and strategy; your ability to make the tough calls and rally the troops; your talents, your charisma, your heroic moments of courage and instinct. But leadership really isn't about you. It's about empowering other people as a result of your presence, and about making sure that the impact of your leadership continues into your absence.

That's the fundamental principle we've learned in the course of dedicating our careers to making leaders and organizations better. Your job as a leader is to create the conditions for your people to fully realize their own capacity and power. And that's true not only when you're in the trenches with them but also when you're not around and even—this is the cleanest test—when you've permanently moved on from the team. We call it empowerment leadership. The more trust you build, the more possible it is to practice this kind of leadership.

THE CORE DRIVERS OF TRUST

So how do you build up stores of this foundational leadership capital? In our experience, trust has three core drivers: authenticity, logic, and empathy. People tend to trust you



MANAGING PEOPLE

when they believe they are interacting with the real you (authenticity), when they have faith in your judgment and competence (logic), and when they feel that you care about them (empathy). When trust is lost, it can almost always be traced back to a breakdown in one of these three drivers.

People don't always realize how the information (or more often, the misinformation) that they're broadcasting may undermine their own trustworthiness. What's worse, stress tends to amplify the problem, causing people to double down on behaviors that make others skeptical. For example, they might unconsciously mask their true selves in a job interview, even though that's precisely the type of less-than-fully-authentic behavior that reduces their chance of being hired.

The good news is that most of us generate a stable pattern of trust signals, which means a small change in behavior can go a long way. In moments when trust is broken, or fails to get any real traction, it's usually the same driver that has gone wobbly on us—authenticity, empathy, or logic. We call this driver your “trust wobble.” In simple terms, it's the driver that's most likely to fail you.

Everybody, it turns out, has a trust wobble. To build trust as a leader, you first need to figure out what yours is.

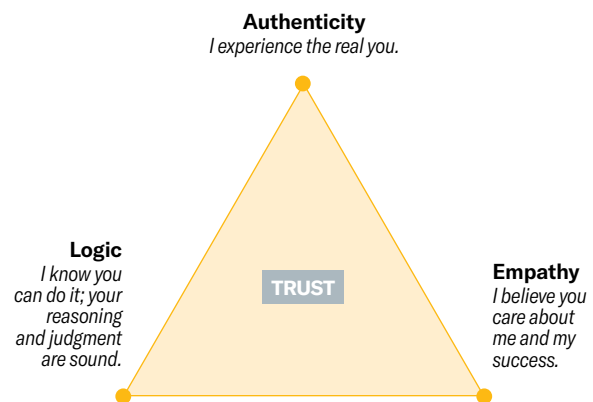
BUILD IT, AND THEY WILL COME

To identify your wobble, think of a recent moment when you were not trusted as much as you wanted to be. Maybe you lost an important sale or didn't get a stretch assignment. Maybe someone simply doubted your ability to execute. With that moment in mind, do something hard: Give the other person in your story the benefit of the doubt. Let's call that person your “skeptic.” Assume that your skeptic's reservations were valid and that you were the one responsible for the breakdown in trust. This exercise only works if you own it.

If you had to choose from our three trust drivers, which would you say went wobbly on you in this situation? Did your skeptic feel you were misrepresenting some part of yourself or your story? If so, that's an authenticity problem. Did your skeptic feel you might be putting your own interests first?

The Trust Triangle

Trust has three drivers: authenticity, logic, and empathy. When trust is lost, it can almost always be traced back to a breakdown in one of them. To build trust as a leader, you first need to figure out which driver you “wobble” on.



If so, that's an empathy problem. Did your skeptic question the rigor of your analysis or your ability to execute on an ambitious plan? If so, that's a logic problem.

Now stand back and try to look at your pattern of wobbles across multiple incidents. Pick three or four interactions that stand out to you, for whatever reason, and do a quick trust diagnostic for each one. What does your typical wobble seem to be? Does the pattern change under stress or with different kinds of stakeholders? For example, do you wobble on one trait with your direct reports but on a different one with people who have authority over you? That's not uncommon.

This exercise works best if you bring at least one person along for your diagnostic ride, ideally someone who knows you well. Sharing your analysis can be clarifying—even liberating—and will help you test and refine your hypothesis. In our experience, about 20% of self-assessments need a round of revision, so choose a partner who can keep you honest. Consider going back and testing your analysis directly by speaking openly about it with your skeptic. This conversation alone can be a powerful way to rebuild trust. When you



Your job as a leader is to help your people fully realize their own capacity and power.
The more trust you build, the more possible it is to practice this kind of leadership.

take responsibility for a wobble, you reveal your humanity (authenticity) and analytic chops (logic) while communicating your commitment to the relationship (empathy).

OVERCOMING YOUR WOBBLE

Over the past decade we've helped all kinds of leaders—from seasoned politicians to Millennial entrepreneurs to the heads of multibillion-dollar companies—wrestle with trust issues. In doing so, we've learned a lot about strategies you can deploy to overcome your own trust wobbles. Let's explore what's most effective for each of the drivers in our trust triangle.

Empathy. Most high-achieving leaders struggle with this one. Signaling a lack of empathy is a major barrier to empowerment leadership. If people think you care more about yourself than about others, they won't trust you enough to lead them.

Empathy wobbles are common among people who are analytical and driven to learn. They often get impatient with those who aren't similarly motivated or who take longer than they do to understand something. Additionally, the tools and experience of the modern workplace continually distract or prevent us from demonstrating empathy, by imposing 24-hour demands on our time and putting at our disposal all sorts of technologies that compete for our attention at any given moment. Our beeping and buzzing devices constantly assert our self-importance, sometimes smack in the middle of interactions with the very people we're working to empower and lead.

We advise empathy wobblers to pay close attention to their behavior in group settings, particularly when other people have the floor. Consider what often happens in a meeting: When it kicks off, most people feel very engaged. But as soon as empathy wobblers understand the concepts under discussion and have contributed their ideas, they lose interest. Their engagement plummets and remains low until the gathering (mercifully) comes to an end. Instead of paying attention, they often multitask, check their phones, engage in flamboyant displays of boredom—anything to make clear that this meeting is beneath them.

Unfortunately, the cost of these indulgences is trust. If you signal that you matter more than everyone else, why should anyone trust the direction you're going in? What's in it for the rest of us to come along?

There's a basic solution to this problem. Instead of focusing on what you need in that meeting, work to ensure that everyone else gets what they need. Take radical responsibility for the others in the room. Share the burden of moving the dialogue forward, even if it's not your meeting. Search for the resonant examples that will bring the concepts to life, and don't disengage until everyone else in the room understands. This is almost impossible to do if texting or checking email is an option, so put away your devices. Everyone knows you're not taking notes on their good ideas.

Indeed, the last thing we'll say on empathy is this: If you do nothing else to change your behavior, put away your phone more frequently. Put it truly away, out of sight and out of reach, not just flipped over for a few minutes at a time. You'll be amazed at the change in the quality of your interactions and your ability to build trust.

Logic. If people don't always have confidence in the rigor of your ideas, or if they don't have full faith in your ability to deliver on them, then logic is probably your wobble. If they don't trust your judgment, why would they want you at the wheel?

When logic is the problem, we advise going back to the data. Root the case you're making in sound evidence, speak about the things you know to be true beyond a reasonable doubt, and then—this is the hard part—stop there. One reason Larry Bird was such an extraordinary basketball player was that he only took shots he knew he could reliably make. That choice made him different from other great players who let ego and adrenaline cloud their shooting judgment. Bird studied and practiced so relentlessly that by the time the ball left his hands in the heat of competition, he knew exactly where it was going. If logic is your wobble, take Bird's example and learn to “play within yourself.”

Once you get comfortable with how that feels, start expanding what you know. Along the way, make an effort to learn from other people. Their insight is among your most valuable resources, but to access it, you must be willing to reveal that you don't have all the answers—something leaders often resist. Engaging people about their experience



has the additional benefit of communicating who you are and what energizes you professionally—an authenticity boost.

For most logic wobblers, however, rigor isn't the issue. Much of the time, the problem is the perception of wobbly logic rather than the reality of it. Why does this happen? Because they're not communicating their ideas effectively.

There are generally two ways to communicate complex thoughts. The first takes your audience on a journey, with twists and turns and context and dramatic tension, until they eventually get to the payoff. Many of the world's best storytellers use this technique. You can visualize this approach by imagining an inverted triangle. The journeying storyteller starts at the top, at the inverted base of the triangle, and traces an enchantingly meandering route down to its point.

If logic is your wobble, however, that's a risky path to take. With all that circuitous journeying, you're likely to lose your audience along the way rather than build trust in your judgment. Listeners may even abandon you at one of your narrative turns.

To avoid that, try flipping the imaginary triangle upright. Start with your main point, or headline, at the top of the triangle, and then work your way down, building a base of reinforcing evidence. This approach signals a clarity of vision and a full command of the facts. Everyone has a much better chance of following your logic. Even if you get interrupted along the way, you'll at least have had a chance to communicate your key idea.

Authenticity. If people feel they're not getting access to the "real" you—to a full and complete accounting of what you know, think, and feel—then you probably have an authenticity wobble.

A quick test: How different is your professional persona from the one that shows up around family and friends? If there's a sharp difference, what are you getting in return for masking or minimizing certain parts of yourself? What's the payoff?

Being your "real self" sounds nice in theory, but there can be powerful reasons for holding back certain truths. The calculation can be highly practical at times, if wrenching—as in deciding to stay closeted in a workplace that's hostile to queer identities. There may also be times when expressing your authentic feelings may risk harmful consequences: Women, for example, are disproportionately penalized for displaying negative emotions in the workplace, and black men are burdened by the false stereotype that they are predisposed to anger. We're not talking here about moments of prudent self-censorship, which sometimes can't be divorced from a larger context of bias or low psychological safety. Instead, we're talking about inauthenticity as a strategy, a way of navigating the workplace. If this is how you operate, you're dealing with an authenticity wobble.

In our experience, although withholding your true self may sometimes help you solve problems in the short term, it puts an artificial cap on trust and, by extension, on your ability to lead. When people sense that you're concealing the



truth or being less than authentic, they're far less willing to make themselves vulnerable to you in the ways that leadership demands.

We've observed the cost of inauthenticity up close in the performance of diverse teams. Diversity can be a tremendous asset in today's marketplace, and the companies that get it right often enjoy powerful competitive tailwinds. But this advantage isn't automatic. Simply populating your team with diverse perspectives and experiences doesn't always translate into better performance. In fact, the uncomfortable truth is that diverse teams can underperform homogenous teams if they're not managed actively for differences among members. That is due in part to a phenomenon called the *common information effect*, which works like this: As human beings, we tend to focus on the things we have in common with other people. We tend to seek out and affirm our shared knowledge, because it confirms our value and kinship with the group. Diverse teams, by definition, have less common information readily available to them to use in collective decision-making.

Consider two teams of three people, one in which the three members are different from one another, and the other in which they're similar. If both teams are managed in exactly the same way—if they simply follow the same best practices in group facilitation, for example—the homogenous team is likely to perform better. No amount of feedback or number of trust falls can overcome the strength of the common information effect.

But the effect only holds if people wobble on authenticity. When they choose to bring their unique selves to the table—that is, the parts of themselves that are different from other people—they can create an unbeatable advantage by expanding the amount of information the team can access. The result is an inclusive team that's likely to outperform (by a long shot) both homogenous teams and diverse teams that aren't actively managed for inclusion. (See the sidebar "Trust, Diversity, and Team Performance.")

This expansion of knowledge and its obvious benefits rely on the courage of authenticity wobblers. We know how difficult sharing who we really are can be, and we also know that it's sometimes too much to ask. But if we regularly give in to the pressure to hold back our unique selves, then we suppress the most valuable parts of ourselves. Not only do we end up concealing the very thing the world needs most from us—our differences—but we also make it harder for people to trust us as leaders.

Here's the reason to care, even if you don't see yourself as different: All of us pay the price of inauthentic interactions, and all of us have a better chance of thriving in inclusive environments where authenticity can flourish. Gender bias, in other words, is not just a woman's problem. Systemic racism is not just an African-American or Latinx problem. It's our shared moral and organizational imperative to create workplaces where the burdens of being different are shouldered by all of us. After all, we will all benefit wildly from eliminating them.



MANAGING PEOPLE

One of the lessons we've learned in our work with organizations is that creating spaces where authenticity can thrive is not as hard as it may seem. It is an urgent, achievable goal that requires far less audacity than disrupting industries or growing complex organizations—things leaders do every day with deep conviction in the outcomes. If all of us take responsibility for creating companies where difference can thrive, and all of us take responsibility for showing up in them authentically, then our chances of achieving true inclusion—and building high levels of trust—start to look pretty good.

So pay less attention to what you think people want to hear and more attention to what you need to say to them. Reveal your full humanity to the world, regardless of what your critics say. And while you're at it, take exquisite care of people who are different from you, confident in the knowledge that their difference is the very thing that could unleash your potential and your organization's.

IN MYSELF I TRUST

We've argued that the foundation of empowerment leadership is getting other people to trust you. That's certainly true, but there's one last thing you need to know. The path to empowerment leadership doesn't begin when other people start to trust you. It begins when you start to trust yourself.

To be a truly empowering leader, you need to take stock of where you wobble not only in your relationships with others but also in your relationship with yourself. Are you being honest with yourself about your ambitions, or are you ignoring what really excites and inspires you? If you're hiding something from yourself, you've got an authenticity problem you need to address. Do you acknowledge your own needs and attend properly to them? If not, you've got to adopt a more empathetic posture toward yourself. Do you lack conviction in your own ideas and ability to perform? If so, you've got some logic issues to work out.

Doing this work is important as a leader, for an arguably obvious reason. If you don't trust yourself, why should anybody else trust you?

A CAMPAIGN TO REBUILD TRUST

Let's now return to Uber. When we began working with the company, it was certainly wobbling—so much so that we diagnosed it as “a hot mess.”

What was going on?

Consider the basic trust-related facts. There's no question that Uber had empathy problems. The company's focus on growth at all costs meant that relationships with stakeholders, particularly drivers and employees, needed real attention. Riders also needed to be assured that their safety wouldn't come second to the company's financial performance. Additionally, despite its disruptive success, Uber hadn't answered questions about the long-term viability of its business model or about whether its managers had the skills to lead an organization of its expansive scale and scope. These were unaddressed logic problems. Finally, the company's war-room mentality was undermining its authenticity. In the “us versus them” culture at Uber, people were skeptical that they were getting the full story.

By the time Frances began working with Kalanick, he had already begun making changes to steady the company's trust wobbles. He had hired Eric Holder, for example, who had served as U.S. attorney general under President Obama, to lead a rigorous internal investigation into harassment and discrimination—and when Holder made a sweeping set of recommendations, Kalanick took action to implement them. The company was also on the verge of rolling out new driver-tipping functionality, which would go on to generate \$600 million in additional driver compensation in the first year of its launch. New safety features were in development, too, designed to give both drivers and riders additional tools to protect themselves.

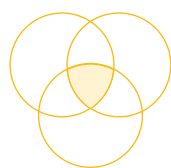
Kalanick didn't get the chance to see most of these initiatives to completion, at least not from the CEO chair. In June 2017, he was forced out as CEO, although he retained his board seat and an equity stake in the company until December 2019, when he gave both up. He was ultimately replaced by Dara Khosrowshahi, the former Expedia CEO, who had a track record of effective leadership at the helm of young companies.



The path to empowerment leadership doesn't begin when other people trust you. It begins when you trust yourself.

Trust, Diversity, and Team Performance

Diversity doesn't automatically confer advantages in decision-making. In fact, if diverse teams aren't managed actively for inclusion, they can underperform homogenous ones. That's because shared knowledge is key in decision-making, and diverse teams, by definition, start out with less of it. But if you create conditions of trust that allow diverse team members to bring their unique perspectives and experiences to the table, you can expand the amount of knowledge your team can access—and create an unbeatable advantage.



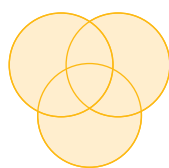
Diverse teams

A diverse store of knowledge is partly shared.



Homogenous teams

A common store of knowledge is fully shared.



Inclusive teams

A diverse store of knowledge is fully shared.

Frances soon began working with Khosrowshahi to continue the campaign to rebuild trust internally. Together they led an effort to rewrite the company's cultural values, one that invited input from all 15,000 employees on the principles that they wanted Uber to live by. The new motto they settled on was "We do the right thing. Period." Other early trust wins for Khosrowshahi included strengthening relationships with regulators and executing a logic-driven focus on the services and markets that were most defensible.

Most of the work we did during this period was aimed at rebuilding trust at the employee level. Some things were easy to identify and fix, like ratcheting down the widespread, empathy-pulverizing practice of texting during meetings about the other people in the meeting, a tech-company norm that shocked us when we first experienced it. We introduced a new norm of turning off all personal technology and putting it away during meetings, which forced people to start making eye contact with their colleagues again.

Other challenges were harder to tackle, like the need to upskill thousands of managers. Our take was that Uber had underinvested in its people during its period of hypergrowth, leaving many managers unprepared for the increasing

complexity of their jobs. We addressed this logic wobble with a massive infusion of executive education, using a virtual classroom to engage employees in live case discussions—our pedagogy of choice—whether they were in San Francisco, London, or Hyderabad. Although our pilot program was voluntary and classes were sometimes scheduled at absurdly inconvenient times, 6,000 Uber employees based in more than 50 countries each participated in 24 hours of instruction over the course of 60 days. It was an extraordinary pace, scale, and absorption of management education.

The curriculum gave people tools and concepts to develop quickly as leaders while flipping a whole lot of upside-down communication triangles. Employees gained the skills not only to listen better but also to talk in ways that made it easier to collaborate across business units and geographies. Frances went out in the field, visiting key global offices in her first 30 days on the job, carving out protected spaces to listen to employees and communicate leadership's commitment to building a company worthy of its people. At a time when many employees were conflicted about their Uber affiliations, Frances made it a point to wear an Uber T-shirt every day until the entire company was proud to be on the payroll.

Within a year, Uber was less wobbly. There were still problems to be solved, but indicators such as employee sentiment, brand health, and driver compensation were all heading in the right direction, and the march toward an IPO began in earnest. Good people were deciding to stay with the company, more good people were joining, and, in what had become our favorite indicator of progress, an increasing number of Uber T-shirts could now be spotted on city streets. It was all a testament to the talent, creativity, and commitment to learning at every level of the organization—and to the new foundation of trust that Kalanick and Khosrowshahi had been able to build. ©

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FRANCES FREI is the UPS Foundation Professor of Service Management at Harvard Business School. She received shares in Uber as compensation for her work with the company, which she continues to hold. **ANNE MORRIS** is an entrepreneur and the executive founder of the Leadership Consortium. They are the authors of *Unleashed: The Unapologetic Leader's Guide to Empowering Everyone Around You* (Harvard Business Review Press, 2020), from which this article was adapted.

There comes a point in your career when the best way to figure out how you're doing is to step back and ask yourself a few questions. Having all the answers is less important than knowing what to ask.

What to Ask the Person in the Mirror

by Robert S. Kaplan

Included with this full-text *Harvard Business Review* article:

1 Article Summary

The Idea in Brief—*the core idea*

The Idea in Practice—*putting the idea to work*

3 What to Ask the Person in the Mirror

13 Further Reading

A list of related materials, with annotations to guide further exploration of the article's ideas and applications

What to Ask the Person in the Mirror

The Idea in Brief

If you're like most managers, the higher you go up the corporate ladder, the harder it is to get candid feedback on your performance. And without crucial input from bosses and colleagues, you can make mistakes that irreparably damage your organization—and your reputation.

How to figure out how you're *really* doing and avoid business disasters? Kaplan recommends looking to *yourself* for answers. Regularly ask yourself questions like these: "Am I communicating a vision for my business to my employees?" "Am I spending my time in ways that enable me to achieve my priorities?" "Do I give people timely and direct feedback they can act on?" "How do I behave under pressure?"

It's far more important to ask the *right* questions than to have all the answers. By applying this process, you tackle the leadership challenges that inevitably arise during the course of your career—and craft new plans for staying on your game.

The Idea in Practice

Kaplan suggests periodically asking yourself questions related to seven leadership challenges:

To address this leadership challenge...	Ask...	Because...
Vision and priorities	How often do I communicate a vision and key priorities to achieve that vision?	Employees want to know where the business is going and what they need to focus on in order to help drive the business. As the world changes, they want to know how the vision and priorities might change.
Managing time	Does the way I spend my time match my key priorities?	Tracking your use of time can reveal startling—even horrifying—disconnects between your top priorities and your actions. Such disconnects send confusing messages to employees about your true priorities.
Feedback	Do I give people timely and direct feedback they can act on?	Employees want truthful, direct, and timely feedback. Retention and productivity improve when employees trust you to raise issues promptly and honestly.
Succession planning	Have I identified potential successors?	It's important to nurture future leaders who can grow the business. If you haven't identified possible successors, you're probably not delegating as much as you should, and you may even be a decision-making bottleneck.
Evaluation and alignment	Am I attuned to business changes that may require shifts in how we run the company?	All businesses encounter challenges posed by changes; for example, in customers' needs or the business's stage of maturity. To determine how best to evolve your business, regularly scan for changes, seek fresh perspectives from talented subordinates, and envision new organizational designs.
Leading under pressure	How do I behave under pressure?	During crises, employees watch you with a microscope—and mimic your behavior. By identifying your unproductive behaviors under pressure (such as blaming others or losing your temper), you can better manage those behaviors and avoid sending unintended messages to employees about how <i>they</i> should behave.
Staying true to yourself	Does my leadership style reflect who I truly am?	A business career is a marathon, not a sprint. If you've adopted a leadership style that doesn't suit your skills, values, and personality, you'll wear down.

There comes a point in your career when the best way to figure out how you're doing is to step back and ask yourself a few questions. Having all the answers is less important than knowing what to ask.

What to Ask the Person in the Mirror

by Robert S. Kaplan

If you're like most successful leaders, you were, in the early stages of your career, given plenty of guidance and support. You were closely monitored, coached, and mentored. But as you moved up the ladder, the sources of honest and useful feedback became fewer, and after a certain point, you were pretty much on your own. Now, your boss—if you have one—is no longer giving much consideration to your day-to-day actions. By the time any mistakes come to light, it's probably too late to fix them—or your boss's perceptions of you. And by the time your management missteps negatively affect your business results, it's usually too late to make corrections that will get you back on course.

No matter how talented and successful you are, you will make mistakes. You will develop bad habits. The world will change subtly, without your even noticing, and behaviors that once worked will be rendered ineffective. Over a 22-year career at Goldman Sachs, I had the opportunity to run various businesses and to work with or coach numerous business leaders.

I chaired the firm's senior leadership training efforts and cochaired its partnership committee, which focused on reviews, promotions, and development of managing directors. Through this experience and subsequent interviews with a large number of executives in a broad range of industries, I have observed that even outstanding leaders invariably struggle through stretches of their careers where they get off track for some period of time.

It's hard to see it when you're in the midst of it; changes in the environment, competitors, or even personal circumstances can quietly guide you off your game. I have learned that a key characteristic of highly successful leaders is not that they figure out how to always stay on course, but that they develop techniques to help them recognize a deteriorating situation and get back on track as quickly as possible. In my experience, the best way to do that is to step back regularly, say every three to six months (and certainly whenever things feel as though they aren't going well), and honestly ask yourself some questions about how you're doing

and what you may need to do differently. As simple as this process sounds, people are often shocked by their own answers to basic management and leadership questions.

One manager in a large financial services company who had been passed over for promotion told me he was quite surprised by his year-end performance review, which highlighted several management issues that had not been previously brought to his attention. His boss read several comments from the review that faulted him for poor communication, failure to effectively articulate a strategy for the business, and a tendency to isolate himself from his team. He believed that the review was unfair. After 15 years at the company, he began to feel confused and misunderstood and wondered whether he still had a future there. He decided to seek feedback directly from five of his key contributors and longtime collaborators. In one-on-one meetings, he asked them for blunt feedback and advice. He was shocked to hear that they were highly critical of several of his recent actions, were confused about the direction he wanted to take the business, and felt he no longer valued their input. Their feedback helped him see that he had been so immersed in the day-to-day business that he had failed to step back and think about what he was doing. This was a serious wake-up call. He immediately took steps to change his behavior and address these issues. His review the following year was dramatically better, he was finally promoted, and his business's performance improved. The manager was lucky to have received this feedback in time to get his career back on track, although he regretted that he had waited for a negative review to ask basic questions about his leadership activities. He promised himself he would not make that mistake again.

In this article, I outline seven types of questions that leaders should ask themselves on some periodic basis. I am not suggesting that there is a "right" answer to any of them or that they all will resonate with a given executive at any point in time. I am suggesting that successful executives can regularly improve their performance and preempt serious business problems by stepping back and taking the time to ask themselves certain key questions.

Vision and Priorities

It's surprising how often business leaders fail

to ask themselves: *How frequently do I communicate a vision and priorities for my business? Would my employees, if asked, be able to articulate the vision and priorities?* Many leaders have, on paper, a wealth of leadership talents: interpersonal, strategic, and analytic skills; a knack for team building; and certainly the ability to develop a vision. Unfortunately, in the press of day-to-day activities, they often don't adequately communicate the vision to the organization, and in particular, they don't convey it in a way that helps their people understand what they are supposed to be doing to drive the business. It is very difficult to lead people if they don't have a firm grasp of where they're heading and what's expected of them.

This was the problem at a large *Fortune* 200 company that had decided to invest in its 1,000 top managers by having them attend an intensive, two-day management-training program, 100 at a time. Before each session, the participants went through a 360-degree nonevaluative review in which critical elements of their individual performance were ranked by ten of their subordinates. The company's senior management looked at the results, focusing on the top five and bottom five traits for each group. Despite this being an extremely well-managed firm, the ability to articulate a vision ranked in the bottom five for almost every group. Managers at that company did articulate a vision, but the feedback from their subordinates strongly indicated that they were not communicating it frequently or clearly enough to meet their people's tremendous hunger for guidance.

Employees want to know where the business is going and what they need to focus on. As the world changes, they want to know how the business vision and priorities might change along with it. While managers are taught to actively communicate, many either unintentionally undercommunicate or fail to articulate specific priorities that would give meaning to their vision. However often you think you discuss vision and strategy, you may not be doing it frequently enough or in sufficient detail to suit the needs of your people. Look at the CEO of an emerging biotechnology company, who was quite frustrated with what he saw as a lack of alignment within his top management team. He strongly believed that the company needed to do a substantial equity financing within the next 18 months, but his senior managers wanted to wait a few years until

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two or three of the company's key drugs were further along in the FDA approval process. They preferred to tell their story to investors when the company was closer to generating revenue. When I asked him about the vision for the company, the CEO sheepishly realized that he had never actually written down a vision statement. He had a well-articulated tactical plan relating to each of the company's specific product efforts but no fully formed vision that would give further context to these efforts. He decided to organize an off-site meeting for his senior management team to discuss and specifically articulate a vision for the company.

After a vigorous debate, the group quickly agreed on a vision and strategic priorities. They realized that in order to achieve their shared goals, the business would in fact require sub-

stantial financing sooner rather than later—or they would need to scale back some of the initiatives that were central to their vision for the company. Once they fully appreciated this trade-off, they understood what the CEO was trying to accomplish and left the meeting united about their financing strategy. The CEO was quite surprised at how easy it had been to bring the members of his leadership team together. Because they agreed on where they were going as a company, specific issues were much easier to resolve.

A common pitfall in articulating a vision is a failure to boil it down to a manageable list of initiatives. Culling the list involves thinking through and then making difficult choices and trade-off decisions. These choices communicate volumes to your people about how they

Testing Yourself

To assess your performance and stay on track, you should step back and ask yourself certain key questions.

Vision and Priorities

In the press of day-to-day activities, leaders often fail to adequately communicate their vision to the organization, and in particular, they don't communicate it in a way that helps their subordinates determine where to focus their own efforts.

How often do I communicate a vision for my business?

Have I identified and communicated three to five key priorities to achieve that vision?

If asked, would my employees be able to articulate the vision and priorities?

Managing Time

Leaders need to know how they're spending their time. They also need to ensure that their time allocation (and that of their subordinates) matches their key priorities.

How am I spending my time? Does it match my key priorities?

How are my subordinates spending their time? Does that match the key priorities for the business?

Feedback

Leaders often fail to coach employees in a direct and timely fashion and, instead, wait until the year-end review. This approach may

lead to unpleasant surprises and can undermine effective professional development. Just as important, leaders need to cultivate subordinates who can give them advice and feedback during the year.

Do I give people timely and direct feedback that they can act on?

Do I have five or six junior subordinates who will tell me things I may not want to hear but need to hear?

Succession Planning

When leaders fail to actively plan for succession, they do not delegate sufficiently and may become decision-making bottlenecks. Key employees may leave if they are not actively groomed and challenged.

Have I, at least in my own mind, picked one or more potential successors?

Am I coaching them and giving them challenging assignments?

Am I delegating sufficiently? Have I become a decision-making bottleneck?

Evaluation and Alignment

The world is constantly changing, and leaders need to be able to adapt their businesses accordingly.

Is the design of my company still aligned with the key success factors for the business?

If I had to design my business with a clean sheet of paper, how would I design it? How would it differ from the current design?

Should I create a task force of subordinates to answer these questions and make recommendations to me?

Leading Under Pressure

A leader's actions in times of stress are watched closely by subordinates and have a profound impact on the culture of the firm and employees' behavior. Successful leaders need to be aware of their own stress triggers and consciously modulate their behavior during these periods to make sure they are acting in ways that are consistent with their beliefs and core values.

What types of events create pressure for me?

How do I behave under pressure?

What signals am I sending my subordinates? Are these signals helpful, or are they undermining the success of my business?

Staying True to Yourself

Successful executives develop leadership styles that fit the needs of their business but also fit their own beliefs and personality.

Is my leadership style comfortable? Does it reflect who I truly am?

Do I assert myself sufficiently, or have I become tentative?

Am I too politically correct?

Does worry about my next promotion or bonus cause me to pull punches or hesitate to express my views?

The fact is, having 15 priorities is the same as having none at all.

should be spending their time. I spoke with the manager of a national sales force who felt frustrated that his direct reports were not focusing on the tasks necessary to achieve their respective regional sales goals. As a result, sales were growing at a slower rate than budgeted at the beginning of the year. When I asked him to enumerate the three to five key priorities he expected his salespeople to focus on, he paused and then explained that there were 15 and it would be very difficult to narrow the list down to five.

Even as he spoke, a light went on in his head. He realized why there might be a disconnect between him and his people: They didn't know precisely what he wanted because he had not told them in a prioritized, and therefore actionable, manner. He reflected on this issue for the next two weeks, thinking at length about his own experience as a regional manager and consulting with various colleagues. He then picked three priorities that he felt were crucial to achieving sales growth. The most important of these involved a major new-business targeting exercise followed by a substantial new-prospect calling effort. The regional managers immediately understood and began focusing on these initiatives. The fact is that having 15 priorities is the same as having none at all. Managers have a responsibility to translate their vision into a manageable number of priorities that their subordinates can understand and act on.

Failing to communicate your vision and priorities has direct costs to you in terms of time and business effectiveness. It's hard to delegate if your people don't have a good sense of the big picture; hence you end up doing more work yourself. This issue can cascade through the organization if your direct reports are, in turn, unable to communicate a vision and effectively leverage their own subordinates.

Managing Time

The second area to question is painfully simple and closely relates to the first: *How am I spending my time?* Once you know your priorities, you need to determine whether you're spending your time—your most precious asset—in a way that will allow you to achieve them. For example, if your two major priorities are senior talent development and global expansion but you're spending the majority of your time on domestic operational and admin-

istrative matters that could be delegated, then you need to recognize there is a disconnect and you'd better make some changes.

It's such a simple question, yet many leaders, myself included, just can't accurately answer at times. When leaders finally do track their time, they're often surprised by what they find. Most of us go through periods where unexpected events and day-to-day chaos cause us to be reactive rather than acting on a proscribed plan. Crises, surprises, personnel issues, and interruptions make the workweek seem like a blur. I have recommended to many leaders that they track how they spend each hour of each day for one week, then categorize the hours into types of activities: business development, people management, and strategic planning, for example. For most executives, the results of this exercise are startling—even horrifying—with obvious disconnects between what their top priorities are and how they are spending their time.

For example, the CEO of a midsize manufacturing company was frustrated because he was working 70 hours a week and never seemed to catch up. His family life suffered, and, at work, he was constantly unavailable for his people and major customers. I suggested he step back and review how he was managing his time hour-by-hour over the course of a week. We sat down to examine the results and noticed that he was spending a substantial amount of time approving company expenditures, some for as little as \$500—this in a business with \$500 million in sales. Sitting in my office, he struggled to explain why he had not delegated some portion of this responsibility; it turned out that the activity was a holdover from a time when the company was much smaller. By delegating authority to approve recurring operating expenses below \$25,000, he realized he could save as much as 15 hours per week. He was amazed that he had not recognized this issue and made this simple change much earlier.

How you spend your time is an important question not only for you but for your team. People tend to take their cues from the leader when it comes to time management—therefore, you want to make sure there's a match between your actions, your business priorities, and your team's activities. The CEO of a rapidly growing, 300-person professional services firm felt that, to build the business, senior managers needed to develop stronger and more substantive rela-

tionships with clients. This meant that senior professionals would need to spend significantly more time out of their offices in meetings with clients. When asked how his own time was being spent, the CEO was unable to answer. After tracking it for a week, he was shocked to find that he was devoting a tremendous amount of his time to administrative activities related to managing the firm. He realized that the amount of attention he was paying to these matters did not reflect the business's priorities and was sending a confusing message to his people. He immediately began pushing himself to delegate a number of these administrative tasks and increase the amount of time he spent on the road with customers, setting a powerful example for his people. He directed each of his senior managers to do a similar time-allocation exercise to ensure they were dedicating sufficient time to clients.

Of course, the way a leader spends his or her time must be tailored to the needs of the business, which may vary depending on time of year, personnel changes, and external factors. The key here is, whatever you decide, time allocation needs to be a conscious decision that fits your vision and priorities for the business. Given the pressure of running a business, it is easy to lose focus, so it's important to ask yourself this question periodically. Just as you would step back and review a major investment decision, you need to dispassionately review the manner in which you invest your time.

Feedback

When you think about the ways you approach feedback, you should first ask: *Do I give people timely, direct, and constructive feedback?* And second: *Do I have five or six junior people who will tell me things I don't want to hear but need to hear?*

If they're like most ambitious employees, your subordinates want to be coached and developed in a truthful and direct manner. They want to get feedback while there's still an opportunity to act on it; if you've waited until the year-end review, it's often too late. In my experience, well-intentioned managers typically fail to give blunt, direct, and timely feedback to their subordinates.

One reason for this failure is that managers are often afraid that constructive feedback and criticism will demoralize their employees. In addition, critiquing a professional in a frank and timely manner may be perceived as overly

confrontational. Lastly, many managers fear that this type of feedback will cause employees not to like them. Consequently, leaders often wait until year-end performance reviews. The year-end review is evaluative (that is, the verdict on the year) and therefore is not conducive to constructive coaching. The subordinate is typically on the defensive and not as open to criticism. This approach creates surprises, often unpleasant ones, which undermine trust and dramatically reduce the confidence of the subordinate in the manager.

The reality is that managers who don't give immediate and direct feedback often are "liked" until year-end—at which time they wind up being strongly disliked. If employees have fallen short of expectations, the failing is reflected in bonuses, raises, and promotions. The feeling of injustice can be enormous. What's worse is the knowledge that if an employee had received feedback earlier in the year, it is likely that he or she would have made meaningful efforts to improve and address the issues.

While people do like to hear positive feedback, ultimately, they desperately want to know the truth, and I have rarely seen someone quit over hearing the truth or being challenged to do better—unless it's too late. On the contrary, I would argue that people are more likely to stay if they understand what issues they need to address and they trust you to bring those issues to their attention in a straightforward and prompt fashion. They gain confidence that you will work with them to develop their skills and that they won't be blindsided at the end of the year. Employees who don't land a hoped-for promotion will be much more likely to forgive you if you've told them all along what they need to do better, even if they haven't gotten there yet. They may well redouble their efforts to prove to you that they can overcome these issues.

During my career at Goldman Sachs, I consistently found that professional development was far more effective when coaching and direct feedback were given to employees throughout the year—well in advance of the annual performance review process. Internal surveys of managing directors showed that, in cases where feedback was confined to the year-end review, satisfaction with career development was dramatically lower than when it was offered throughout the year.

While your direct reports know what you are doing wrong, most of them are not dying to tell you. It takes a concerted effort to cultivate subordinates who will advise and coach you.

As hard as it is to give effective and timely feedback, many leaders find it much more challenging to get feedback from their employees. Once you reach a certain stage of your career, junior people are in a much better position than your boss to tell you how you're doing. They see you in your day-to-day activities, and they experience your decisions directly. Your boss, at this stage, is much more removed and, as a result, typically needs to talk to your subordinates to assess your performance at the end of the year. In order to avoid your own year-end surprises, you need to develop a network of junior professionals who are willing to give you constructive feedback. The problem is that, while your direct reports know what you are doing wrong, most of them are not dying to tell you. With good reason—there's very little upside and a tremendous amount of downside. The more senior and the more important you become, the less your subordinates will tell you the "awful truth"—things that are difficult to hear but that you need to know.

It takes a concerted effort to cultivate subordinates who will advise and coach you. It also takes patience and some relentlessness. When I ask subordinates for constructive feedback, they will typically and predictably tell me that I'm doing "very well." When I follow up and ask "What should I do differently?" they respond, "Nothing that I can think of." If I challenge them by saying, "There must be something!" still they say, "Nothing comes to mind." I then ask them to sit back and think—we have plenty of time. By this time, beads of sweat begin to become visible on their foreheads. After an awkward silence, they will eventually come up with something—and it's often devastating to hear. It's devastating because it's a damning criticism and because you know it's true.

What you do with this feedback is critical. If you act on it, you will improve your performance. Equally important, you will take a big step in building trust and laying the groundwork for a channel of honest feedback. When subordinates see that you respond positively to suggestions, they will often feel more ownership in the business and in your success. They'll learn to give you criticisms on their own initiative because they know you will actually appreciate it and do something with it. Developing a network of "coaching" subordinates will help you take action to identify your own lead-

ership issues and meaningfully improve your performance.

Succession Planning

Another question that managers know is important yet struggle to answer affirmatively is: *Have I, at least in my own mind, picked one or more potential successors?* This issue is critical because if you aren't identifying potential successors, you are probably not delegating as extensively as you should and you may well be a decision-making bottleneck. Being a bottleneck invariably means that you are not spending enough time on vital leadership priorities and are failing to develop your key subordinates. Ironically, when leaders believe they are so talented that they can perform tasks far better than any of their subordinates and therefore insist on doing the tasks themselves, they will typically cause their businesses to underperform, and, ultimately, their careers will suffer as well.

The succession question also has significant implications that cascade through an organization: If leaders do not develop successors, then the organization may lack a sufficient number of leaders to successfully grow the business. Worse, if junior employees are not developed, they may leave the firm for better opportunities elsewhere. For these reasons, many well-managed companies will hesitate to promote executives who have failed to develop successors.

It is sufficient to identify possible successors without actually telling them you've done so—as long as this identification causes you to manage them differently. In particular, you will want to delegate more of your major responsibilities to these professionals. This will speed their maturation and prepare them to step up to the next level. By giving demanding assignments to these subordinates, you strongly signal an interest in their development and career progression—which will encourage them to turn down offers from competitors. Leaders who do this are much better able to keep their teams together and avoid losing up-and-coming stars to competitors.

A loss of talent is highly damaging to a company. It is particularly painful if you could have retained key employees by simply challenging them more intensively. I spoke with a division head of a large company who was concerned about what he perceived to be a talent deficit

in his organization. He felt that he could not use his time to the fullest because he viewed his direct reports as incapable of assuming some of his major responsibilities. He believed this talent deficit was keeping him from launching several new product and market initiatives. In the midst of all this, he lost two essential subordinates over six months—each had left to take on increased responsibilities at major competitors. He had tried to persuade them to stay, emphasizing that he was actively considering them for significant new leadership assignments. Because they had not seen evidence of this previously, they were skeptical and left anyway. I asked him whether, prior to the defections, he had identified them (or anyone else) as potential successors, put increased responsibilities in their hands, or actively ratcheted up his coaching of these professionals. He answered that, in the chaos of daily events and in the effort to keep up with the business, he had not done so. He also admitted that he had underestimated the potential of these two employees and realized he was probably underestimating the abilities of several others in the company. He immediately sat down and made a list of potential stars and next to each name wrote out a career and responsibility game plan. He immediately got to work on this formative succession plan, although he suspected that he had probably waited too long already.

When you're challenging and testing people, you delegate to them more often, which frees you to focus on the most critical strategic matters facing the business. This will make you more successful and a more attractive candidate for your own future promotion.

Evaluation and Alignment

The world is constantly changing. Your customers' needs change; your business evolves (going, for instance, from high growth to mature); new products and distribution methods emerge as threats. When these changes happen, if you don't change along with them, you can get seriously out of alignment. The types of people you hire, the way you organize them, the economic incentives you offer them, and even the nature of the tasks you delegate no longer create the culture and outcomes that are critical to the success of your business. It's your job to make sure that the design of your organization is aligned with the key success factors for the business. Ask your-

self: *Am I attuned to changes in the business environment that would require a change in the way we organize and run our business?*

Such clear-sightedness is, of course, hard to achieve. As a leader, you may be too close to the business to see subtle changes that are continually occurring. Because you probably played a central role in building and designing the business, it may be emotionally very difficult to make meaningful changes. You may have to fire certain employees—people you recruited and hired. You may also have to acknowledge that you made some mistakes and be open to changing your own operating style in a way that is uncomfortable for some period of time.

Because of the difficulty in facing these issues, it's sometimes wise to call on high-potential subordinates to take a fresh look at the business. This approach can be quite effective because junior employees are often not as emotionally invested as you are and can see more objectively what needs to be done. This approach is also a good way to challenge your future leaders and give them a valuable development experience. You'll give them a chance to exercise their strategic skills; you'll get a glimpse of their potential (which relates to the earlier discussion of succession planning), and you might just get some terrific new ideas for how to run the business.

This approach worked for the CEO of a high technology business in northern California, whose company had been one of the early innovators in its product space but, in recent years, had begun to falter and lose market share. In its early days, the company's primary success factors had been product innovation and satisfying customer needs. It had aggressively hired innovative engineers and marketing personnel. As new competitors emerged, customers began to focus more on cost and service (in the form of more sophisticated applications development). Stepping back, the CEO sensed that he needed to redesign the company with a different mix of people, a new organization, and a revised incentive structure. Rather than try to come up with a new model himself, he asked a more junior group of executives to formulate a new company design as if they had a "clean sheet of paper." Their study took a number of weeks, but upon completion, it led to several recommendations that the CEO immediately began to implement. For example, they suggested colocating the engineering and sales de-

If you aren't identifying potential successors, you are probably not delegating as extensively as you should.

partments and creating integrated account coverage teams. They also recommended that the company push more of its engineers to interact with customers and focus on this skill in recruiting. The CEO regretted that he had not asked the question—and conducted this assignment—12 months earlier.

Even the most successful business is susceptible to new challenges posed by a changing world. Effective executives regularly look at their businesses with a clean sheet of paper—seeking advice and other perspectives from people who are less emotionally invested in the business—in order to determine whether key aspects of the way they run their organizations are still appropriate.

Leading Under Pressure

Pressure is a part of business. Changes in business conditions create urgent problems. New entrants in the market demand a competitive response. Valued employees quit, often at the most inopportune times. Leaders and their teams, no matter how smart they are, make mistakes.

The interesting thing about stressful events is that they affect each person differently—what causes you anxiety may not bother someone else, and vice versa. For some, extreme anxiety may be triggered by the prospect of a promotion; for others, by making a serious mistake; still others, by losing a piece of business to a competitor. Regardless of the source of stress, every leader experiences it, so a good question to ask yourself is: *How do I behave under pressure, and what signals am I sending my employees?*

As a leader, you're watched closely. During a crisis, your people watch you with a microscope, noting every move you make. In such times, your subordinates learn a great deal about you and what you really believe, as opposed to what you say. Do you accept responsibility for mistakes, or do you look for someone to blame? Do you support your employees, or do you turn on them? Are you cool and calm, or do you lose your temper? Do you stand up for what you believe, or do you take the expedient route and advocate what you think your seniors want to hear? You need to be self-aware enough to recognize the situations that create severe anxiety for you and manage your behavior to avoid sending unproductive messages to your people.

I've met a number of leaders who behave in a very composed and thoughtful manner the great majority of the time. Unfortunately, when they're under severe stress, they react in ways that set a very negative tone. They inadvertently train their employees to mimic that behavior and behave in a similar fashion. If your instinct is to shield yourself from blame, to take credit rather than sharing it with your subordinates, or to avoid admitting when you have made a mistake, you will give your employees license to do the same.

The CEO of a large asset-management firm was frustrated that he was unable to build a culture of accountability and teamwork in his growing business. At his request, I spoke to a number of his team members. I asked in particular about the actions of the CEO when investments they recommended declined in value. They recounted his frequent temper tantrums and accusatory diatribes, which led to an overwhelming atmosphere of blame and finger-pointing. The investment decisions had, in fact, been made jointly through a carefully constructed process involving portfolio managers, industry analysts, and the CEO. As a result of these episodes, employees learned that when investments went wrong it would be good to try to find someone else to blame. Hearing these stories, the CEO realized his actions under pressure were far more persuasive to employees than his speeches about teamwork and culture. He understood that he would have to learn to moderate his behavior under stress and, subsequently, took steps to avoid reacting so angrily to negative investment results. He also became more aware that subordinates typically felt quite regretful and demoralized when their investments declined and were more likely to need a pat on the back and coaching than a kick in the pants.

It's extremely difficult to expect employees to alert you to looming problems when they fear your reaction—and even more so when they think it's better to distance themselves from potential problems. This can create an atmosphere where surprises are, in fact, more likely as the company's natural early-warning system has been inadvertently disarmed. If you have created this kind of culture, it is quite unlikely that you will learn about problems from subordinates spontaneously—unless they want to commit career suicide.

Part of the process of maturing as a leader is learning to step back and think about what creates pressure for you, being self-aware in these situations, and disciplining your behavior to ensure that you act in a manner consistent with your core values.

Staying True to Yourself

Most business leaders ask themselves whether their leadership style fits the needs of their business. Fewer managers ask whether their style also fits their own beliefs and personality. The question here is: *Does my leadership style reflect who I truly am?*

A business career is a marathon, not a sprint, and if you aren't true to yourself, eventually you're going to wear down. As you are developing in your career, it is advisable to observe various leadership styles, and pick and choose elements that feel comfortable to you. Bear in mind, though, that observing and adopting aspects of other styles does not mean you should try to be someone else. During my career, I was fortunate to have had several superb bosses and colleagues with distinctive and unique leadership skills. While I tried to adopt some of their techniques, I also learned that I needed to develop an overall style that fit my unique skills and personality. Your style needs to fit you; even an unorthodox style can be enormously effective if it reflects your skills, values, and personality.

As you become more senior, you'll need to ask yourself an additional set of questions relating to style: *Do I assert myself sufficiently, or have I become tentative? Am I too politically correct? Does worry about my next promotion or my year-end bonus cause me to pull punches or hesitate to clearly express my views?* In many companies, ambitious executives may try to avoid confronting sensitive issues or making waves. Worse than that, they may spend an inordinate amount of energy trying to ascertain what their boss thinks and then act like they think the same thing. If they're very skilled at this, they may even get a chance to make their comments before the boss has a chance

to express his opinion—and feel the warm glow of approval from the boss.

The problem is that confrontation and disagreement are crucial to effective decision making. Some of the worst decisions I've been involved in were made after a group of intelligent people had unanimously agreed to the course of action—though, later, several participants admitted that they had misgivings but were hesitant to diverge from the apparent group consensus. Conversely, it's hard for me to recall a poor decision I was involved in that was made after a thorough debate in which opposing views were vigorously expressed (even if I disagreed with the ultimate decision). Companies need their leaders to express strongly held views rather than mimic what they believe to be the party line. As a leader, therefore, you must ask yourself whether you are expressing your views or holding back and being too politic. At the same time, leaders must encourage their own subordinates to express their unvarnished opinions, make waves as appropriate, and stop tiptoeing around significant issues.

...

Successful leaders periodically struggle during stretches of their careers. To get back on track, they must devise techniques for stepping back, getting perspective, and developing a new game plan. In this process, having the answers is often far less important than taking time to ask yourself the right questions and gain key insights. The questions posed in this article are intended to spark your thinking. Only a subset of these may resonate with you, and you may find it more useful to come up with your own list. In either event, a self-questioning process conducted on a periodic basis will help you work through leadership challenges and issues that you invariably must tackle over the course of your career.

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All too often, leaders fail to explain what they mean when they talk about organizational structure, financial results, their own jobs, time management, and corporate culture. Left unclear, these concepts can throw a firm into turmoil—but when given proper focus, they confer extraordinary leverage.

The Five Messages Leaders Must Manage

by John Hamm

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The Five Messages Leaders Must Manage

by John Hamm

If you want to know why so many organizations sink into chaos, look no further than their leaders' mouths. Leadership, at any level, certainly isn't easy—but unclear, vague, roller-coaster pronouncements make many top managers' jobs infinitely more difficult than they need to be. Leaders frequently espouse dozens of cliché-infused declarations such as "Let's focus on the key priorities this quarter," "Customers come first," or "We need a full-court press in engineering this month." Over and over again, they present grand, overarching—yet fuzzy—notions of where they think the company is going. Too often, they assume everyone shares the same definitions of broad terms like vision, loyalty, accountability, customer relationships, teamwork, focus, priority, culture, frugality, decision making, results, and so on, virtually ad infinitum.

Even the most senior managers nod in polite agreement when the CEO uses inflated terms like these, but the executives may feel somewhat discomfited, wondering whether they've truly understood. Rather than asking

for clarification—a request they fear would make them look stupid—they pass on vague marching orders to their own troops, all of whom develop their own interpretations of what their bosses mean. In the absence of clear communication that satisfies the urgent desire to know what the boss is really thinking, people imagine all kinds of motives. The result is often sloppy behavior and misalignment that can cost a company dearly. Precious time is wasted, rumors abound, talented people lose their focus, big projects fail.

By contrast, think of the way a high-reliability team—say, an emergency room staff or a SWAT team—works. Every member has a precise understanding of what things mean. Surgeons and nurses speak the same medical language. SWAT teams know exactly what weapons to use, and when and how and under what conditions to use them. In these professions, there is absolutely no room for sloppy communication. If team members don't speak to each other with precision, people die. People don't die in corporations, but without clear

definitions and directions from the top, they work ineffectively and at cross-purposes.

For the past five years, I've worked with hundreds of CEOs as a leadership coach, a board member, a venture capital investor, and a strategy consultant. I've also been a president and CEO myself (my company, Whistle Communications, was acquired by IBM in 1999). The companies whose CEOs I've worked with—typically technology firms—range in size from about 100 to several thousand people. In observing CEOs, I've come to the conclusion that the real job of leadership is to inspire the organization to take responsibility for creating a better future. I believe effective communication is a leader's single most critical management tool for making this happen. When leaders take the time to explain what they mean, both explicitly (by carefully defining their visions, intentions, and directions) and implicitly (through their behavior), they assert much-needed influence over the vague but powerful notions that otherwise run away with employees' imaginations. By clarifying amorphous terms and commanding and managing the corporate vocabulary, leaders effectively align precious employee energy and commitment within their organizations.

In researching this topic, I have discovered that many leaders don't take the time to define specifically what they mean when they use generalized terms or clichés. They don't want to feel that they are talking down to people by providing what seems like unnecessary detail or context. Leaders simply assume that the exact meaning of their words is obvious; they're surprised to learn not only that their message has been unclear but that their teams crave definitions so they aren't forced to guess what the boss has in mind.

If we accept that the leader's job, at its core, is to inspire and support the organization's collective responsibility to create a better future for the company, then what are the keys to effectiveness? What tools do leaders need at hand for this mission? What mental models must they have? I like to think of good leaders as comparable to skilled locomotive drivers. The train is controlled by a set of switches and levers. When the driver pulls one lever, the train goes forward; when he pulls another, it stops, and so on. When an organization is well aligned, all the managerial levers are easily and neatly moved. They function smoothly so

that driver, passengers, and train gracefully move forward as one.

In my experience, five such topics control the train: organizational structure and hierarchy, financial results, the leader's sense of his or her job, time management, and corporate culture. Messages on these subjects wield extraordinary influence within the firm. When leaders take it for granted that everyone in the organization shares their assumptions or knows their mental models regarding the five subject areas, they lose their grip on the managerial levers and soon have the proverbial runaway train on their hands. But properly defined, disseminated, and controlled, the five topics afford the leader opportunities for organizational alignment, increased accountability, and substantially better performance.

Before examining each one, I'd like to address a few possible objections head-on. First, why do these five particular topics matter so much—why would defining corporate culture be a higher priority than, say, defining customer relationships? Certainly, other terms carry a premium in some organizations, but I've found that these five are excellent places to start and are highly representative of the kind of difficulties that exist for leaders as they speak to their teams day to day. The topics not only present the sharpest examples of the dangers of imprecise communication, but, when mastered, they also produce the greatest leadership leverage.

I am hardly suggesting that in defining the five concepts precisely, leaders should become dictators or blowhards. On the contrary, I am suggesting that when a leader defines what he or she really means and sets a clear direction according to that definition, relationships and feedback improve, action is more efficient and on-strategy, and improved performance follows.

Message 1: Organizational Structure and Hierarchy

The organizational chart, because it represents individual power or influence, is an emotionally charged framework even during a company's most stable times. But when the corporate structure is changing, the org chart can truly become fearsome, particularly in companies where, because of the political culture, employees worry about risk to their personal status.

If a CEO fails to take definitional control of a reorganization, with its prospect of job losses, boss changes, and new modes of working, the

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whole company can grind to a halt. Consider what happened when one well-known former CEO allowed the default assumptions surrounding the term “reorganization” to take hold. A few years ago, Carly Fiorina decided that Hewlett-Packard needed a top-to-bottom reshuffling. She had a fixed idea that reorganizations must be managed with extreme care, and she implicitly communicated her belief by the cautious way she floated her ideas with senior managers. She worried that a reshuffling plan would open a Pandora’s box of political sensitivities, especially among middle managers. For this reason, everyone assumed that “reorganization” was cause for fear and trembling.

For two months prior to Fiorina’s official announcement, work slowed or stopped as employees, not knowing precisely what to expect or fear, shifted their focus to the upcoming changes. Managers, jostling for power and position, got lost in political battles. Motivation plummeted. Contractors were put off, since no one knew who would be managing which divisions after the reorganization. When the new organizational structure was finally communicated, still more time passed unproductively as employees settled into their new positions. A total of 12 weeks—a full quarter—were effectively lost. If you multiply that time by employee salaries, and factor in the inevitable lapses in customer service and product innovation during the period, you can conservatively estimate the damage to the company.

It may be unreasonable to blame Fiorina for failing to realize that she was communicating her trepidation, or to fault her for not divining the consequences of talking about her reorganization ideas months ahead of time. After all, leaders cannot be held to perfection in execution. But they *can* be held to a standard when communicating a vision and its rationale. If Fiorina had laid out the master plan behind the reorganization more clearly, made her decisions more quickly, and communicated more explicitly, the troops at HP would have gained a better understanding of the process, the reasons for the extended time frame, and their future places within the company.

A leader who quickly takes charge of the communication around a reorganization can prevent the discourse from engendering fear. The most productive way for a leader to think about organizational structure is as a flexible map of accountability for action and, thus, re-

sults—a guideline whose purpose is to define goals and optimize resources, not to oust or devalue employees. When a reorganization is presented as such, it loses its reputation as a proxy for personal power shifts, whether real or imagined.

The CEO of a 150-employee software company shows how a leader can prevent political fears from taking hold by keeping communications brief and to the point. Rather than viewing the org chart as a source of anxiety, and communicating that attitude to the company, the CEO chose to see it as simply a temporary structure for optimizing resources. When a new strategy or direction was called for, he enlisted people as active agents of change, so they wouldn’t be left to wonder whether they were to become victims. For example, the CEO realized at one point that he needed to realign internal resources because a close competitor was gaining an advantage. He called an all-hands meeting for a Monday morning. “Team,” he said, “we’re in a war for market share. I get paid to win it, and so do you. But right now I don’t think we’re properly configured to win the particular battle we’re fighting, so I’m changing the structure of resources so that we can execute more effectively. Most of you will continue to do the jobs you’re doing now, but you may have a different supervisor.” After showing everyone the new organization chart, he looked at his watch. “It’s 10:45 now,” he said. “You have until noon to be annoyed, should that be your reaction. At noon, pizza will be served. At one o’clock, we go to work in our new positions.”

The CEO later explained what he did: “We had a competitor who was showing us a better way to win the business. We were both like captains of firefighting teams. We each had seven people and a full set of buckets and hoses. My team had five guys armed with buckets and two with hoses. His team had three guys with buckets and four with hoses. We just weren’t organized to compete and win. I wasn’t trying to shift power; I was just trying to optimize our resources. I wasn’t willing to let this change be viewed as a political event. I wanted it to be seen as a business necessity to remain competitive.”

Obviously, it’s one thing to shift personnel in a 150-person company and quite another to do so in a giant corporation like HP. But I would argue that the value of clear, honest, explicit

When a reorganization is presented as simply a guideline for defining goals and optimizing resources, it loses its reputation as a proxy for shifts in personal power.

communication rises exponentially with the size of the organization. In fact, a large company can be reshuffled much more quickly when the CEO deliberately decides not to inflate the political balloon and won't tolerate others doing so.

Having gathered the data and made her decision, Fiorina was under no obligation to provide previews of coming attractions. Within 48 hours of the announcement, she might have held a companywide meeting, complete with a Webcast, to explain why the change was necessary. To keep people's minds off who was headed down and who was headed up, she could have asked everyone involved in the changes to identify and submit, in short order, explicit goals for the next 60 days. She thus would have communicated that the organization chart has nothing to do with politics and everything to do with organizational effectiveness.

Message 2: Financial Results

"Results" is another powerful concept that, left unmanaged, poses a risk to a company's long-term health. When a top executive tells employees they need to "focus on our promised results," senior managers often interpret that as meaning "Do whatever it takes to meet investors' expectations." By losing sight of the connection between employee behavior and results, and failing to take advantage of learning opportunities, leaders miss out on building long-term value for their firms.

One CEO I knew truly believed that the only purpose of his job was to make aggressive predictions and promises about quarterly results and then achieve the numbers by any means possible. By the ninth week of every quarter, when projections fell short, he put enormous pressure on his sales professionals and finance people. His implicit message was: "These are the results I need; I don't care how you get it done." He fully expected the company to thrive.

Quite the opposite occurred. Because the CEO defined "results" so narrowly and failed to properly motivate or compensate his selling team, the sales force had no compunction about stuffing the sales channel. Though the company never met with any punitive action, its poor practices forced recalculations of results and exposed it to huge write-downs. Revenues stalled at \$10 million a quarter, and the company was eventually acquired at a discount to its annual revenues.

In the long term, consistently positive results spring from intelligent strategy and an incessant focus on quality of execution. Think of a golf pro like Tiger Woods, whose best bet for winning major championships is to master his aim, setup, and swing. Once the ball is in the air, there is no way to control it; it will land where it will. Similarly, effective leaders understand that there is more leverage in using quarterly results as a metric for long-term improvement than in worrying only about short-term market wins. By using results as a diagnostic tool in the service of improving future execution, and by asking employees to participate in the analysis, effective leaders encourage honesty and engage their troops in open dialogue. Employees are more likely to generate good ideas, and the firm is more likely to surpass financial expectations quarter after quarter.

I had the pleasure of working for six years under John Adler, former CEO of the technology firm Adaptec. During his 12 years at the helm, Adler drove the company's valuation from \$100 million to over \$5 billion because he had a very healthy attitude about business goals and financial results. For him, results were not a punitive weapon but a useful diagnostic and learning tool. When the firm, at one point, missed a quarterly goal, he and his management team analyzed all the factors contributing to the shortfall. They discovered that, as a result of an unusual quality-control issue, the company had been unable to make some end-of-quarter shipments. Instead of reacting emotionally and assigning blame, Adler asked rigorous questions of the senior management team, which was able to uncover the root cause of the problem. He communicated this information broadly to ensure organizational learning. By focusing on and taking responsibility for the truth, Adler made others in the company feel safe to discuss the issue without fear of an emotional response that might lead to arbitrary punishment.

Through his actions, Adler sent an implicit message that the past was over and tomorrow was another day. Rather than being immobilized by uncertainty and wondering who would be forced to take the heat, software engineers and quality assurance technicians worked together to improve their processes to minimize the probability of missing sales projections because of last-minute quality or manufacturing glitches. From that point forward, the com-

If a top executive says employees need to "focus on our promised results," senior managers often interpret that to mean "Do whatever it takes to meet investors' expectations."

pany's track record for quality was the envy of the industry. By adjusting his "swing," Adler was able to achieve accurate, consistently excellent results for the duration of his tenure.

Message 3: The Leader's Sense of His or Her Job

CEOs wear many hats and play many roles in the service of leadership, but, surrounded by people who seek their feedback and approval, some fall into the trap of thinking that their responsibility is to be the person who has all the answers. (This is especially true of entrepreneurial CEOs who are also founders, because their identities are closely tied with their companies.) The "answer man" falsely believes himself to be the final arbiter of conflicts, decisions, and dilemmas. This puts him in a very lonely, isolated position where information becomes unreliable and useful input is stifled.

A CEO I'll call Jim, who ran a once blazingly successful and now defunct desktop-publishing software firm, had been told his whole life that he was brilliant—and he was. The recipient of an MBA from Stanford and a PhD from MIT and the holder of ten software patents, Jim was also a Midas: Everything he touched seemed to turn to gold. It wasn't much of a leap for him to assume that because he was so smart, he necessarily knew what was best for the company. Jim took great comfort in this assumption; indeed, since he was deeply insecure in other leadership areas, his identity rested on it.

Though Jim made a point of hiring the best and the brightest from top engineering and business schools, he didn't listen to his new team. Strategy, for example, was not Jim's strongest suit, but he believed he knew best how to combat competitive threats. When his managers made suggestions for staving off the competition, Jim ignored them, using his positional power to drown out discussion. He'd say of a rival company: "There's no way those guys could be close to our technology. I've met the CEO there and I know we can beat them. I will explain what we have to do." While forceful and somewhat persuasive, he was out of touch with market reality, and his team knew it. Frustrated, his managers soon grasped the implicit message that they were neither heard nor valued, and they began to flee the company, taking much intellectual capital with them. Jim, oblivious to perceptions of his own behavior,

was baffled by the exodus, telling himself that the people who left didn't "get it."

Effective leaders, by contrast, understand that their role is to bring out the answers in others. They do this by very clearly and explicitly seeking contributions, challenges, and collaboration from the people who report to them, using their positional power not to dominate but rather to drive the decision-making process. The more collaborative and apolitical that process is, the less isolated the leader, and the greater the likelihood that the business strategy will be grounded in reality.

Contrast Jim's understanding and communication of his role to that of a CEO I'll call Chris, who ran a technology research firm. Chris, too, was brilliant and confident—top of his class at Harvard and a military hero in the Gulf War—but instead of expressing his intelligence arrogantly, he conveyed curiosity. In functional meetings, he communicated that for the duration of the session, he wouldn't wield his positional power as CEO but instead would be just another contributor of ideas. He listened to everyone's point of view before expressing his own. He posed questions and challenged opinions. In one meeting with his marketing team, he listened to presentations from public relations, marketing, and advertising managers. When he finally spoke, he noted that the company had outspent competitors in a bid to raise visibility for its flagship product but had yet to make a dent in competitors' market share. He asked that a smaller group convene within a week to find out why. Aware that the "boss's answer" would stifle the group's creativity and thus do more harm than good, he resisted the temptation to state his own theory.

In asking his team to be accountable for diagnosing the problem, Chris didn't accuse anyone or cast blame. He thereby conveyed that his role was to help the team process information. He made it clear to the people who worked for him that it was not his job to provide the answers, but rather to help find the best solutions. His authentically collaborative approach encouraged the smart people around him to contribute their ideas. The task force generated a half dozen thoughtful and feasible theories and several comprehensive recovery plans, the most compelling of which was put into action. It produced the hoped-for changes in market share in the next three quarters. In the process, several ideas for other successful marketing campaigns

were born. As a result of his leadership, Chris's firm established itself as a powerhouse of intellectual capital in the technology arena. His company is now regarded as a unique source of market information and is paid handsome fees to publish its findings.

Like the Level 5 leaders Jim Collins describes, Chris led by separating his ego from his job. Leaders like Chris understand that their role is to ask great questions, and they know that answers can be found as long as employ-

ees feel safe offering them. Accordingly, the entire team moves the company forward.

Message 4: Time Management

Every executive feels that time is in short supply. Organizers, time management classes, and administrative assistants remind us of the time we don't have. Obsessed with deadlines, managers struggle against constraints by trying to squeeze, manipulate, and control the limited hours in the day. When the CEO gives employees the message that time is the boss, the "to-do list" mentality can easily subsume important goals.

Allow me to illustrate with an extreme-sounding but true example of a CEO with whom I worked. Alan, as I'll call him, was the busy head of a midsize technology firm in Silicon Valley. A former engineer who was ruled by his Day-Timer, to-do list, and BlackBerry, he started every day feeling that he was "behind," long before the opening bell on Wall Street. The time management system was his scripture, efficiency his credo, and prioritizing his Job 1. Alan's fixed idea was that time was the enemy; he communicated this message to his team, telling the members that by managing time better than their counterparts at rival firms, they could drive the company to success. His obsession with time created a palpable anxiety.

When economic conditions in the valley worsened, Alan was forced to impose a moratorium on head-count growth. Then the company received a request for proposal from BellSouth. Alan jumped at the opportunity to make a big software sale and focused his already stretched workforce on the project. Implicitly, time management became the operational currency of the organization. Alan became even more conscious of employees' use of time, so he separated elements of the project into streams, telling his direct reports where and how to use their hours and minutes to produce the RFP. When he was giving feedback to his direct reports, his first question was about how they used the time they devoted to their work. Despite everyone's efforts, however, there weren't enough hours in the day to keep up.

The company submitted the RFP on time, all its i's dotted and t's crossed, then waited with bated breath for what Alan was certain would be a positive response from BellSouth. But the company lost to a firm with inferior technology. The problem had less to do with the content of the proposal than with the way

Change Your Mind-Set

When executives assume that managerial topics are understood the same way by everyone, they surrender the opportunity to lead effectively. Leaders who

explicitly say what they mean are better able to leverage the energy and commitment of their followers.

1 MESSAGE Organizational structure and hierarchy	CONVENTIONAL MENTAL MODEL Make the org chart a proxy for politics.	TRY THIS Optimize human resources.
2 MESSAGE Financial results	CONVENTIONAL MENTAL MODEL Penalize misses. Blame someone.	TRY THIS Perform a diagnostic to determine the root cause of any shortfalls.
3 MESSAGE The leader's sense of his or her job	CONVENTIONAL MENTAL MODEL The boss has the answers.	TRY THIS Everyone has answers—ask questions.
4 MESSAGE Time management	CONVENTIONAL MENTAL MODEL Time is scarce, so scramble against constraints.	TRY THIS Time is fixed, so choose wisely within constraints.
5 MESSAGE Corporate culture	CONVENTIONAL MENTAL MODEL Hand the responsibility to HR.	TRY THIS Create an environment in which everyone can help the team win.

it was delivered. Alan and his team had created a perfect RFP but failed to invest in any relationship building with anyone at BellSouth. The competitor, by contrast, had developed close relationships with the telecommunications firm. Simply put, Alan's people were so obsessed with meeting tasks on deadline that they had lost sight of the project as a whole, and the customer in particular. It was as if the cooks at Alan's firm had made an exquisite, five-course dinner but had forgotten the wine, the tablecloth, and the flowers and had served the food cold. They delivered what Alan said he expected.

A CEO can be more effective if she communicates to the company that the resource of time must not be squeezed for all it is worth but instead must be strategically utilized. It's a subtle but important distinction. A leader who harps on time constraints and breathes down managers' necks, trying to get them to do too much in the allotted period, can make the organization frantic and, ultimately, ineffective. A leader who communicates that when time is tight, it's better to do fewer things—but do them very well—gives managers the confidence to make the best use of this precious resource. That way, everyone involved works within the time parameters to do what needs to be done.

One leader who understands the importance of communicating properly about time is Mark King, the CEO of TaylorMade-adidas Golf. King desperately wanted to launch an industry-changing product to mark the company's 25th anniversary in the spring of 2004. The golf equipment business, like music, cars, and fashion, is trend driven; King knew that if his company could develop a breakthrough product and launch it at a very powerful point in the industry's history, the company would cement its status as golf's leading performance brand.

At first, King envisioned an entire new line of clubs based on the bold idea of movable weight, and he set all his best engineers working on development. They put in long hours, but as the six-month mark neared, he realized that his objective would be impossible to meet by the anniversary date. He could not ask for more time from the team, nor could he change the deadline. So he changed the goal. TaylorMade would develop a single golf club that would showcase the technology of movable weight, and the product would debut at the

anniversary event in front of hundreds of reporters and industry influencers.

Instead of struggling against time, King shifted his choices within the time constraint. How, he asked himself, could his teams best use their hours? Instead of playing beat the clock by trying to do everything he wished, where could they best focus their energy? How could time be optimized? By understanding that he had a choice about how the limited time could best be used, he was able to free up needed technical and marketing resources and focus on quality and branding.

The new TaylorMade r7 quad driver, unveiled on the anniversary, garnered rave reviews. PGA and European Tour golfers snapped it up. By the time the 2004 PGA and European tours came to an end, half the professionals worldwide owned the new driver, guaranteeing its popularity among the golfing public. A dozen additional products followed, completing the team's vision for the line of clubs. The meal was well planned, cooked, and served. Today, TaylorMade is the fastest growing golf-equipment firm in the world, and its r7 driver is the flagship product in a multihundred-million-dollar product line.

Alan, the technology company CEO, sent the message that time was to be fought against, and he set unreasonable expectations. Mark King's message was that time was not the enemy, just a fact of the situation, and there were other, more controllable levers that could be used to meet the challenges at hand. Alan saw time as a fearsome, inflexible monster, best overcome by brute force; King saw it as a neutral phenomenon, best handled with flexibility. Both men had a strong vision of

84 Great Things

To get an idea of what can happen when a CEO manages time constraints by setting reasonable expectations, imagine that you have seven direct reports, each of whom commits to completing no more than three important, very doable initiatives each quarter. If these reports and their teams meet their goals, four quarters will yield 84 significant accomplishments. If your company were able to do anywhere near 84 significant

things in a single year, the results would no doubt be astonishing. The real enemy to accomplishing 84 great things is the temptation to work on the 85th objective and beyond before, or at the expense of, the higher-priority goals. To keep people on track, a leader must communicate objectives very clearly and demand that action flow to the real priorities first.

what success would look like, but King was willing to make trade-offs in the service of quality. (See the sidebar “84 Great Things.”)

Message 5: Corporate Culture

What is corporate culture, and why is communicating clearly and precisely about it important? Culture is not created by declaration; it derives from expectations focused on winning. You can only have a culture that encourages performance if you hire the right people, require them to behave in a way that is consistent with the values the company espouses, and implement processes that will allow the company to win in the marketplace.

CEOs who fail to define success and communicate their vision of it, and fail to make their expectations clear to employees, produce meaningless cultures. The silly cultural activity arising from the high-tech bubble of the late 1990s is a wonderful example. I remember one Silicon Valley CEO who opened the “culture cupboard” and fed employees with all kinds of treats—Friday beer bashes, foosball tables, and the like. He even hired a “chief culture officer,” an HR executive whose job was making employees feel fleetingly happy, even when the company lost a client or had a bad quarter. The idea was that if people felt good, if they were “empowered” and were working together, then good results would follow naturally. It was all about employee morale and attitude and teamwork. But managers lost sight of core business metrics. In the end, people wanted to work for a firm that did more than cheerlead them—they wanted a share in a successful IPO. Eventually, the company was acquired for mere asset value because instead of developing a winning strategy, the CEO engaged in indulgent avoidance.

A healthy culture is created and maintained by focusing on the right goals and creating the experience of winning in the marketplace. A telephony-software company CEO I’ll call Jeff runs his firm like a high-performing sports team. A big, football-style scoreboard on a conference room wall displays the company metrics—sales, expenses, revenues—for all to see. All personnel in the company, screened for their collaborative as well as their analytical skills, work on six-person teams (according to the U.S. Navy SEALs, six is the ideal number of participants on any high-intensity project). Individuals are only as effective as their teams; everyone in

the firm adheres to a strict set of values and basic standards of conduct. Finally, everyone in the company knows what winning looks like: a P/E ratio of 15, a market share of 20%, and 30% year-over-year revenue growth. If the company’s goal is to make \$20 million by the third quarter, the goal is broken down into strategic parts marked on the scoreboard. The spirit of the company is a function of its collective commitment to success, not the most recent company outing. Successful companies are places where people want to come to work—not to be coddled but to make a difference.

In companies with healthy cultures, employees aren’t kept in the dark; rather, they are supported in the belief that they are part of an exciting future. They come to work with a fire inside them, a result of clearly stated leadership and business practices that everyone explicitly understands. Every person in the company knows how to individually contribute to its future.

...

By recognizing the impact of clear and direct communication and seeking feedback from their teams, leaders leverage, rather than abuse, their positional power. The most effective leaders I know, CEOs who understand that the risks of miscommunication are very high, ask themselves the following questions on their way to work: What needs to happen today so that we can get where we want to go? Where is there confusion in my company? What vague belief or notion can I clarify or debunk today? What have I not communicated completely or clearly? What kinds of things are people taking for granted?

In the end, the power of clear communication is really a game of leverage. A CEO who communicates precisely to ten direct reports, each of whom communicates with equal precision to 40 other talented employees, effectively aligns the organization’s commitment and energy around a clear, well-understood, shared vision of the company’s real goals, priorities, and opportunities. He or she saves the company time, money, and resources and allows extraordinary things to happen.

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Business Communication



How Great Leaders Communicate

Four strategies to motivate and inspire your team. **by Carmine Gallo**

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In the age of knowledge, ideas are the foundation of success in almost every field. You can have the greatest idea in the world, but if you can't persuade anyone else to follow your vision, your influence and impact will be greatly diminished. And that's why communication is no longer considered a "soft skill" among the world's top business leaders. Leaders who reach the top do not simply pay lip service to the importance of effective communication. Instead, they study the art in all its forms — writing, speaking, presenting — and constantly strive to improve on those skills.

For example, while Jeff Bezos was building Amazon, he put a premium on writing skills. In the summer of 2004, he surprised his leadership team and banned PowerPoint. He replaced slides with “narratively structured memos” that contained titles and full sentences with verbs and nouns.

Bezos is not alone among top leaders. “You cannot over-invest in communication skills — written and oral skills,” says [former PepsiCo CEO Indra Nooyi](#), who now serves on Amazon’s board. “If you cannot simplify a message and communicate it compellingly, believe me, you cannot get the masses to follow you.”

During my research for *The Bezos Blueprint*, I found a number of common tactics top leaders use when communicating with their teams. Here are four to try:

1. Use short words to talk about hard things.

Long, complicated sentences make written ideas hard to understand — they’re mentally draining and demand more concentration. You’ll win more fans if you replace long words and sentences with short ones.

“If you care about being thought credible and intelligent, do not use complex language where simpler language will do,” writes Nobel prize-winning economist Daniel Kahneman in *Thinking, Fast and Slow*. He argues that persuasive speakers and writers do everything they can to reduce “cognitive strain.”

Software tools like Grammarly assess writing quality by generating a numerical readability score. The score assigns a [grade level](#) to writing samples. For example, a document written for a person with at least an eighth-grade education (the average 13-year-old in the U.S.) is considered “very easy to read.” It does not imply that your writing

sounds like an eighth grader wrote it. It simply means that your sophisticated arguments are easy to grasp — and ideas that are easy to understand are more persuasive.

Since writing is a skill, you can sharpen it with practice. Bezos improved as a writer over time. His first Amazon shareholder letter in 1997 registered at a tenth-grade level (comparable to The New York Times). Over the next decade, 85% of his letters were written for an eighth- or ninth-grade level.

For example, in 2007, Bezos explained the benefits of Amazon’s newly introduced Kindle in a paragraph a seventh grader could understand:

If you come across a word you don’t recognize, you can look it up easily. You can search your books. Your margin notes and underlinings are stored on the server-side in the “cloud,” where they can’t be lost. Kindle keeps your place in each of the books you’re reading, automatically. If your eyes are tired, you can change the font size. Our vision for Kindle is every book ever printed in any language, all available in less than 60 seconds.

Bezos chose short words to talk about hard things. When you make things simple, you’re not dumbing down the content. You’re outsmarting the competition.

2. Choose sticky metaphors to reinforce key concepts.

A metaphor is a powerful tool that compares abstract ideas to familiar concepts. Metaphors bring people on a journey without ever leaving their seats. Chris Hadfield, a famous Canadian astronaut, is a talented speaker and [TED Talks](#) star who tapped into the power of metaphor to describe an indescribable event:

Six seconds before launch, suddenly, this beast starts roaring like a dragon starting to breathe fire. You're like a little leaf in a hurricane...As those engines light, you feel like you're in the jaws of an enormous dog that is shaking you and physically pummeling you with power.

Roaring beasts, leaves in a hurricane, the jaws of a dog — these are all concrete ideas to describe an event that few of us will ever experience.

In business, metaphors are shortcuts to communicating complex information in short, catchy phrases. Warren Buffett understands the power of metaphor. If you watch business news or follow the stock market, you've no doubt heard the phrase "moats and castles" attributed to companies that dominate an industry that's difficult for competitors to enter. Buffett popularized the phrase at a 1995 Berkshire Hathaway meeting when he said, "The most important thing we do is to find a business with a wide and long-lasting moat around it, protecting a terrific economic castle with an honest lord in charge of the castle."

The castle metaphor is a concise shortcut, a vivid explanation for a complex system of data and information that Buffett and his team use to evaluate potential investments.

When you introduce a new or abstract idea, your audience will automatically search for something familiar to help them make sense of it. Introduce a novel metaphor and beat them to the punch.

3. Humanize data to create value.

The trick to reducing cognitive load and making any data point interesting is to humanize it by placing the number in perspective. Showing them PowerPoint slides with statistics and charts only adds cognitive weight, draining their mental energy.

Any time you introduce numbers, take the extra step to make them engaging, memorable, and, ultimately, persuasive.

For example, by 2025 scientists expect humans to produce 175 zettabytes of data annually (one zettabyte is a trillion gigabytes). It's simply too big a number for most people to wrap their minds around. But what if I said that if you could store 175 zettabytes of data on DVDs, the disks would circle the earth 222 times? It's still a big number, but the description is more engaging because it paints a vivid image in your mind's eye.

Famed astrophysicist and science educator Neil deGrasse Tyson once told me that the secret to science communication is to “embed the concept in familiar ground.” In other words, turn data into language mere humans can understand.

One of Tyson's famous examples of humanizing data occurred in 1997 when NASA launched the Cassini space probe to explore Saturn. Skeptics questioned its \$3 billion price tag, and so Tyson appeared on television talk shows to educate the public on the benefits of the mission. But first, he had to deal with the price shock, so he pulled a data comparison out of his rhetorical toolbelt. He explained that the \$3 billion would be spread over eight years. He added that Americans spend more on lip balm every year than NASA would spend on the mission over that timeline.

To demonstrate the value of your idea, humanize data and make it relevant to your listeners.

4. Make mission your mantra to align teams.

In 1957, a power outage knocked out electricity to large parts of Wisconsin and Minnesota. [Earl Bakken](#), a medical device repairman

working in his garage, saw an opportunity to create innovations in the field. So he built the first battery-powered pacemaker that kept working even when the power went out.

At that moment, Bakken's life took on a purpose beyond just fixing things. He was on a mission to "alleviate pain, restore health, and extend life."

Bakken passed away in 2018, more than 50 years after founding Medtronic. The company has changed considerably since then. Its 90,000 employees work across 150 countries and its therapies touch the lives of two patients every second. But while much has changed, one thing has stayed the same: Medtronic's employees are driven by the same six words that inspired Bakken: alleviate pain, restore health, extend life.

Bakken was a "repeater in chief," constantly keeping the company's mission front and center. Shortly before Bakken passed away at the age of 94, he recorded a video for employees. He repeated the company's mission and made one request: "I ask you to live by it every day."

A mission statement that's tucked in a drawer and largely forgotten does little to align teams around a common purpose. Harvard Business School professor John Kotter found that most leaders under-communicate their vision by a factor of 10. "Transformation is impossible unless hundreds or thousands of people are willing to help, often to the point of making short-term sacrifices," Kotter writes.

Transformational leaders overcommunicate. They repeat the mission so often, it becomes a mantra. A mantra is a statement or slogan that builds in strength as it's repeated. Overcommunication fuels its impact. Your mission should take center stage. Shine a spotlight on your

company's purpose across communication channels: memos, emails, presentations, social media, and marketing material. If your mission stands for something, then stand up for it.

...

Anything worth accomplishing takes the work of a team, a group of people dedicated to the passionate pursuit of a dream, a common vision. While some teams follow leaders who are granted power through sheer title alone, the most successful teams follow leaders because they are *inspired* to do so.

Editors' note (1/3/24): The conversion of zettabytes to gigabytes was incorrect and has been changed.

This article was originally published online on November 23, 2022.



Carmine Gallo is a Harvard University instructor, keynote speaker, and author of 10 books translated into 40 languages. Gallo is the author of [*The Bezos Blueprint: Communication Secrets of the World's Greatest Salesman*](#) (St. Martin's Press).



Case Study

Case Study: Will a Bank's New Technology Help or Hurt Morale?

by Leonard A. Schlesinger



Case Study

Will a Bank's New Technology Help or Hurt Morale?

by Leonard A. Schlesinger

HBR's fictionalized case studies present problems faced by leaders in real companies and offer solutions from experts. This one is based on the HBS Case Study "Athena Bancorp" (case no. 919517-PDF-ENG), by Leonard A. Schlesinger and Sarah L. Abbott, which is available at [HBR.org](https://hbr.org).

"IF WE GROW too fast, we'll break from the strain."

"If we stop growing, we'll be eaten for lunch by our competitors."

Beth Daniels, the CEO of Michigan's Vanir Bancorp, sat silent as her chief human resources officer and chief financial officer traded jabs. The trio had founded their community bank three years earlier with the mission of serving small-business owners, particularly those on the lower end of the credit spectrum. After getting a start-up off the ground in a mature, heavily regulated

industry, they were a tight-knit, battle-tested team. But the current meeting was turning into a civil war.

James Donnold, the CFO, had just presented an update on Vanir's aggressive goals: expanding to 15 branches, with loans and deposits increasing threefold in five years. Having already grown to five branches and \$180 million in assets, the bank was right on track. But, James warned, competitors were circling, and Vanir needed to stay on the offensive. It couldn't let bigger banks lure away the previously underserved



customers that it had brought into the financial system or let new “fintech” start-ups with digital-only banking services disintermediate its business. Luckily, James noted, the company’s long-awaited new enterprise IT was nearly ready to go live, and it promised to greatly reduce the staff’s workload—by, for example, using AI to automate tasks like calculating pricing and credit lines for customers.

That prediction prompted Mariko Wang, the CHRO, to let out an audible scoff. She felt that aggressive growth had already

stretched Vanir too thin and that believing IT would lighten the burden on employees was optimistic. “When was the last time a new technology created *less* work for anyone?” she asked sarcastically.¹

But then her tone turned serious, and she delivered her familiar—compelling—spiel: Working with new or underserved banking customers was extremely arduous. Vanir’s branches were open early and late to accommodate customers’ schedules. To make banking less intimidating, tellers and relationship managers were told to take as long as needed to answer people’s questions. They were trained to be unbiased, whereas some AI tools in the industry had come under criticism for discriminating against minority applicants. And that human touch was what drove growth; loan applicants often had such a great experience at Vanir that they transferred their other accounts to the bank, opened new ones, or recommended it to other small-business owners.

Vanir’s associates enjoyed above-market salaries but also worked harder than their peers at other banks. Considered “essential workers,” they’d even come in to the office during the worst months of the pandemic, managing all the loans that customers had applied for through the U.S. government’s economic relief package. But now employee engagement was down, absenteeism was up, and customers were starting to notice.² Net Promoter Scores had fallen, and comments in customer surveys included complaints like “hassled-looking teller” and “unhelpful manager.”

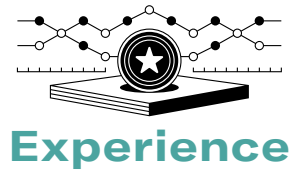
“Our people are our strategy,” Mariko said, locking eyes with

Beth. “Without them happily serving customers, we’re just another bank.”

OFF TO SEE THE WIZARD

Leaving the meeting, Beth felt torn. She’d started Vanir to help hardworking customers who’d been neglected by large banks and poorly served by mismanaged community-development institutions. Her father had been a general contractor, and it infuriated her that the developers he worked for seemed to have unlimited access to debt while he struggled to secure a new loan to upgrade his tools and equipment. She suspected that most of the bigger players were interested in her customers only because they needed a certain number of small-business accounts to meet regulatory mandates and keep their banking charters; after luring small clients away with introductory promotions, the large banks would give them the same shoddy service that had held her father back. Meanwhile, the fintech start-ups were low touch and untested; they could leave their clients high and dry.³

It hurt Beth’s soul to imagine that possibility, so she shared James’s fervor for quickly expanding to serve as many people as possible with the help of technology. The goal was to build a loan underwriting system that would apply proprietary algorithms to create a single score that



Case Study Classroom Notes

1. Is this an effective meeting? How can Beth allow dissent while keeping discourse civil?
2. Academics who study service organizations have found a strong link between employee satisfaction and customer loyalty.
3. One way to make small-business customers more profitable is to force them to use self-service rather than customer service reps.



4. *Cost overruns are not unusual with enterprise IT projects. A study by McKinsey found that on average, large IT projects run 45% over budget.*

5. *Some economists wonder if productivity gains have slowed in developed economies because new technologies make workers more distracted, increase task switching, and create more cybersecurity challenges.*

signaled whether a loan should be approved and what the credit line and the interest rate should be. That promised to free up staff to focus on the face-to-face service that Vanir had become known for.

But building the enterprise IT had taken longer and cost more than anticipated.⁴ Meanwhile, associates had become accustomed to doing the calculations and decision-making themselves, and an inefficient process had become routine. The staff also enjoyed the autonomy the process provided: Lending officers were encouraged to get to know their applicants and to combine objective criteria, such as credit scores, with subjective ones, such as personal character. Still, the strain on the employees was starting to show, and Beth took Mariko's warnings about burnout seriously.

Would a shift to the new system help or hurt Vanir's staff? Certain elements of the transition

would require lots of busywork. For instance, along with the lending algorithms, the IT team had built a customer relationship management system that would allow a review of customer profitability across multiple products. Information on that now was stored in loan officers' heads and hard drives, and getting it into the system would be laborious. As Vanir opened more branches, it would need to hire more associates, who would have to be trained (on, among other things, the new technology) by its existing staffers, further burdening them. Beth hoped that the new system's birth pains would be short-lived and quickly lead to greater efficiency and lighter workloads. But she also worried that in the long term, Vanir's earliest employees would miss the algorithm-free autonomy they'd become accustomed to.

Beth knew she needed to talk to "the wizard," her white-haired,

tie-dyed-T-shirt-wearing chief technology officer, Bruce Richards. "What's the update?" she asked as she entered his office.

"Do you want the good news or the bad news?" he replied, chuckling. Beth frowned and crossed her arms.

"OK," Bruce continued. "The good news is that the entire stack is ready to go. We can roll out tomorrow."

"And the bad news?" Beth asked.

"The bad news is that the pilot we ran in the Lansing branch uncovered some, well, resistance."

"Go on."

"The staff hated it," Bruce said. "The feedback was that no one had time to learn a complicated new system. Some people refused to attend the training. Others brought their laptops to class and worked the entire time."

"Oh," Beth said.

On her way out for the evening, Beth stops by the desk of Chantelle, a relationship manager.

How's morale?

A lot of people are struggling.

I know. But the tech solution is almost ready. Help is on the way.

What makes this bank special is that we're run by people, not by formulas. I'm worried that the algorithm will end up hurting our customers.

"This isn't unexpected!" Bruce interjected. "Learning a new system takes time and can be frustrating. You can expect a period of negative labor productivity before we see any gains, but that doesn't mean the gains won't come."⁵ What matters is that we're finally ready to launch. We can pull the trigger next week if you give us the go-ahead."

"No," Beth replied. "Hold off for now. We might have to delay. I need to think this through."

SOME FRANK FEEDBACK

Beth checked her watch as she collected her coat from her office—8:30 PM. So much for bankers' hours. As she headed out of the branch where the executive team worked, she saw relationship manager Chantelle Williams, one of her first hires, at her desk, turning over pages in a file. Beth knew that Chantelle had two

sons who'd been homeschooling through most of the pandemic.

On Chantelle's desk was one photo of her kids and another of her first Vanir client—a bakery owner who'd had trouble obtaining a loan at other banks because of his prior issues with credit card debt. Following company protocol, Chantelle had looked more closely at his situation and realized that the debt had coincided with his wife's illness four years earlier. Since that time his credit history had been spotless. Vanir had given him a loan, and in return he not only made his monthly payments on time but accompanied them with deliveries of his delicious cannoli. "I don't stay late for you," Chantelle had once told Beth after she'd thanked the manager for her long hours. "I stay late to earn school tuition for them"—she nodded to the picture of her sons—"and," she added, shifting her gaze to the photo of

the baker, "to make sure people like him can stay in business."⁶

"How are you holding up, Chantelle?" Beth asked.

"I'm living the dream, boss!" Chantelle joked, gesturing to the open file on her desk.

"No, really. How's morale?"

"Well," Chantelle said, "a lot of people are struggling. You combine the long hours with challenges on the home front, and it's tough."

"I know," Beth said. "But I just spoke to Bruce Richards, and he said the tech solution is almost ready. Help is on the way."

Chantelle sighed.

"What is it?" Beth asked. "Are you worried about the transition? There will be some work up front, but I assure you that—"

"That's not what I'm worried about," Chantelle interrupted.

"Well, then, what?"

"Look, what makes this bank special is that we are run by



6. Showing employees their positive impact on customers increases their motivation. A 2007 study found that when call center agents soliciting donations for college scholarships met students their work supported, their productivity skyrocketed.

7. How can Vanir ensure that its algorithms are free of racial or minority group bias?



Experience

people, not by formulas. We can make a human connection with our customers. I just don't think an algorithm can replace that. Truthfully, I'm worried that we're going to end up double-checking the algorithm all the time or, worse, that it will end up hurting our customers."

"Absolutely not," Beth said.

"I wouldn't let that happen."

"You know how you call Bruce 'the wizard'?" Chantelle continued. "Well, have you actually looked behind the curtain? Are you sure this technology won't just end up discriminating against the very customers we strive to serve?"⁷

After thanking Chantelle for her candor, Beth wished her a good night and headed for the exit. She knew she faced the biggest decision of her tenure as CEO. Should she rethink the implementation of Vanir's new IT system, knowing full well that her employees were stretched thin but that a delay might allow competitors to pounce on Vanir's current and future customer base? Or should she risk her employees' trust and dedication by pushing past their concerns, sticking to her tech-enabled strategy, and forging ahead? She opened the door and stepped out into the cold Detroit night. ☹

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Should Beth go ahead with the bank's expansion plans and IT rollout?



LYNDA M. APPLGATE

Stakeholder Analysis Tool

A stakeholder is any person, group or organizational unit that will be influenced by (or will influence) the actions you take to accomplish your goals. Stakeholders can be inside or outside your organization and may have positive or negative interests. For example, some stakeholders may know that they will receive benefits from an initiative or project. As such, they would be expected to have a positive interest in your success. Other stakeholders may have concerns that your actions may have a negative effect on their interests. Finally, some stakeholders may have business interests while others have personal interests. For example, your success may require that your spouse and family relocate to another city, which could be considered as either positive or negative.

Review the step-by-step approach below. Then use the tables on the following page to: identify stakeholders and analyze their interests and expectations; categorize interests and expectations based on importance; and develop an action plan.

A Step-by-Step Approach

- Step 1: Define the new venture, initiative or project you plan to launch or are in the process of launching. Then, identify key milestones and the timeframe within which each must be accomplished.
- Step 2: List each individual, group, unit, or organization that has a stake in whether you are successful in accomplishing your goals. These stakeholders may have
- Step 3: Identify each stakeholders' interests and expectations. Put a (+) sign beside those interests or expectations that are positive and a (-) sign beside those interests or expectations that are negative.
- Step 4: Rate the importance of each stakeholder to the successful accomplishment of your goal.
- Step 5: Identify actions you must take to meet, clarify, or realign stakeholder interests and expectations.

Use the table on the next page to identify key stakeholders and to analyze their interests and expectations.

Professor Lynda M. Applegate prepared this exercise as the basis for class discussion rather than to illustrate either effective or ineffective handling of an administrative situation.

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STAKEHOLDER ANALYSIS

Company Name: _____ Reviewer Name: _____ Date _____ of _____
 Analysis:

Briefly describe the new venture, strategic initiative, or project you would like to accomplish:

Stakeholder	Interests/Expectations Put a (+) beside those interests/expectations that you believe will have a positive impact on your goals/strategy and a (-) beside those that you believe will have a negative impact.	Importance 1=Low 3=Neutral 5=High

Comments:

STAKEHOLDER MAP

Company Name:
Analysis:

Reviewer Name:

Date
of

Stakeholder
Interests / Expectations

Positive

Negative

Low

High

Importance
to Success

STAKEHOLDER ACTION PLANNING

Company Name:
Analysis:

Reviewer Name:

Date of

Identify three key issues you need to resolve based on your stakeholder analysis.

Issues	Actions	Comments

Crisis Communication: Lessons from 9/11

by Paul Argenti



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December 2002

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Why Entrepreneurs Don't Scale
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Crisis Communication

Lessons from 9/11

When the worst happens, companies have to put their employees' interests above all else.

by Paul Argenti

AT 8:45 AM on September 11, 2001, John Murphy, the CEO of Oppenheimer Funds, was out for a run in lower Manhattan's Battery Park. He was thinking about the company's reorganization plan, which he had announced the day before, when suddenly he saw an explosion near the top of the north tower of the World Trade Center. He stopped to watch black smoke pour from the place of impact—an awful lot of smoke, it seemed, for what was probably a small plane that had lost its way. He thought of his own employees in the neighboring south tower and made a mental note not to renew Oppenheimer's lease in that building. “First the bombing in 1993 and now a plane accident,” he thought. “What’s next?” He continued jogging, now in the direction of the office.

At the same moment, some 1,600 miles away, Timothy Doke was fighting rush-hour traffic on his way to American Airlines headquarters in Dallas. His pager went off at the same time his cell phone started ringing. As Doke, American's vice president of corporate communications, scrambled to answer the phone and fish the pager out of his

pocket, a sinking feeling came over him—a feeling made worse by a voice on the phone informing him that one of American's flights out of Boston had been hijacked. Doke passed the exit to his office and headed for the next one, which would take him to American's strategic command center, the company's hub for handling crisis situations.

Back in New York City, Mary Beth Bardin was in a cab on the traffic-snarled streets of midtown Manhattan on her way to a breakfast meeting when she, too, saw smoke billowing into the otherwise clear blue skies. “Something must be on fire downtown,” she thought. The cabdriver turned on the radio, and Bardin was stunned to hear that a jetliner had crashed into one of the World Trade Center's towers. Traffic ground to a halt, and Bardin, executive vice president of public affairs and communications at Verizon, jumped out of the cab and headed on foot to her company's offices at 42nd Street and Sixth Avenue. She immediately thought about the 2,200 Verizon employees working in lower Manhattan, especially those located in the World Trade Center and in Verizon Wireless's store there. Could they have

been hurt? Her pace quickened, and she reached for her cell phone to let headquarters know she was on her way in.

...

Many companies have faced disasters in the past. What was unique about the events of September 11 was the breadth of their impact on business. Some companies lost scores of employees. Many others saw key components of their infrastructure destroyed, at least temporarily. A still larger group had to struggle with secondary effects – customers requiring heroic levels of service, suppliers unable to fill orders, breakdowns in transportation and communication, collapses in demand. And every company in the country had to deal with traumatized and bewildered workers. Suddenly, crisis management was every executive's job.

I've spoken with many managers about their experiences and how they responded to the events of 9/11. Some of them, like John Murphy and Mary Beth Bardin, were near Ground Zero. Others, like Tim Doke, were far away from the site of the attacks but were nevertheless buffeted by their impact. What I discovered is that, in a time of extreme crisis, internal communications take precedence. Before any other constructive action can take place – whether it's serving customers or reassuring investors – the morale of employees must be rebuilt. In the words of Ray O'Rourke, managing director for global corporate affairs at Morgan Stanley in New York, "We knew within the first day that, even though we are a financial services company, we didn't have a financial crisis on our hands; we had a human crisis. After that point, everything was focused on our people."

In my conversations with a range of executives, I was able to distill five lessons that I think can serve as guideposts for any company facing a crisis that undermines its employees' composure, confidence, or concentration.

Many of these lessons relate to preparation – to establishing plans and mechanisms for emergency action. But if 9/11 taught us anything, it's that we can't anticipate every contingency. Sometimes, we have no choice but to improvise. Here, too, the experiences I uncovered can serve as useful models. Improvisation, after all, is most effective when a strong corporate mission and vision are already in place to inform and guide it.

Get on the Scene

In a move that would soon attain legendary status, New York City Mayor Rudolph Giuliani arrived at the World Trade Center within minutes of the first attack to take charge of the rescue operation. In the days and weeks that followed, he would conduct several press conferences in the vicinity of the destroyed towers, attend many funerals and memorial services, and maintain what seemed like a ubiquitous presence in the city. His visibility, combined with his decisiveness, candor, and compassion, lifted the spirits of all New Yorkers – indeed, of all Americans.

During the crisis, the most effective managers maintained similarly high levels of visibility in their own organizations. They understood that a central part of their job is political and that their employees are, in a very real sense, their constituents. In periods of upheaval, workers want concrete evidence that top management views their distress as one of the company's key concerns. Written statements have their place, but oral statements and the sound of an empathic human voice communicate sincerity. And if the voice belongs to a company leader, the listener has reason to think that the full weight of the company stands behind whatever promises and assurances are being made. In the words of Rob Densen, Oppenheimer's director of corporate affairs and a survivor of the 1993 bombing of the World Trade Center, most people

engulfed in a crisis "want to be led and accordingly need to trust that you are going to lead them."

As the local telephone service provider to much of New York, Verizon faced enormous business and operational challenges in the wake of the Trade Center attacks. The 2,200 Verizon employees who were situated in the vicinity of the Center were involved in running the densest knot of cables and switches anywhere in the world. The attack knocked out 300,000 voice access lines and 4.5 million data circuits and left ten cellular towers inactive, depriving 14,000 businesses and 20,000 residential customers of service. Within hours, Larry Babbio, the head of the company's telecom business, traveled to the site to inquire after the safety of employees and inspect the damage. The CEO, Ivan Seidenberg, during the week following the attack, worked closely and at length with the communications team to craft and record voice mails addressed to employees who could still be reached outside the area of devastation. These messages went out daily until the stock market reopened the following Monday. "This was a time for leadership, and employees wanted to hear directly from the leader," Bardin says. The messages focused on employee safety, those unaccounted for, the condition of the network, and how Verizon was going to get the New York Stock Exchange open for business. In addition, senior managers toured various facilities to meet with employees, and Seidenberg himself inspected the damage to Verizon's building at 140 West Street.

Employees at the *New York Times* faced a particularly harrowing challenge after the attacks. They were as traumatized as other New Yorkers – the company's main offices are on West 43rd Street, about three miles from Ground Zero, close enough for them to see the smoke. But it was their job to cover the attacks with the clearheadedness and distance of professional journalists. The sheer scale of the event, and its effect on friends and neighbors, shook even the most hard-bitten newsroom veterans. Russell Lewis, CEO of

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the New York Times Company, realized that the leadership team had to be seen acting “calmly, rationally, and humanely” – indeed, to be seen smiling – “so that our staff would mirror our behavior.” One of the first things he did was to go to the building’s fire command station and use its emergency public-address system to assure the staff that, until more was known about the attack, the safest place to be was within the *Times*’ fortress-like headquarters. He would use the system frequently over the next several days to reassure and update employees.

“When people heard us on the speakers, they listened. Your voice must sound calm, in control and, most important, earnest,” says Lewis, thinking back. He, Chairman and Publisher Arthur Ochs Sulzberger, Jr., and *Times* newspaper President Janet Robinson became the crisis management team, walking throughout the building each day to answer employees’ questions concerning such matters as building security and to thank them for their dedication. “Most of all, we wanted people to know we were all in the same boat,” Lewis says.

Communicating with the people actually covering 9/11 was far from unnecessary. “If anything,” he says, “journalists needed more information [than other *Times* employees] about what the company was doing in response to the crisis. They are paid to be skeptical of authority, and if you can’t adequately explain and defend what it is you’re telling them, they won’t go along.”

The presence of senior management wasn’t just important for companies in Manhattan – all around the country, bewildered and frightened employees were hungry for leadership. Think of Dell. It’s headquartered in Texas, and its people suffered little direct impact from the terrorism. Yet they were devastated emotionally. Within a few days of 9/11, CEO Michael Dell and Kevin Rollins, Dell’s president and chief operating officer, out of a simple desire to be involved and heard, decided they would meet with all of their directors and vice presidents, who were encouraged to talk about how they and their teams were

holding up. To keep the meetings small and personal, three were held. The meetings were also taped and put on the company intranet for the benefit of every employee. In a stark departure from business as usual, Dell and Rollins said the focus should not be on sales or margins but rather on Dell’s people and helping affected customers rebuild.

Choose your Channels Carefully

Whether natural or man-made, disasters often disrupt normal flows of communication. Phone lines and power lines may be destroyed. Computer networks may go down. Groups of employees may be stranded or isolated. This was certainly the situation many companies faced after 9/11. To reach their people, managers often had to be creative in using unusual communication channels. Many, for instance, used the mass media to communicate with employees. Oppenheimer Funds, which occupied five floors at Two World Trade

Center and another 1,000 in Five World Trade Center, a smaller structure, had been disabled, as had the internal Web site for its broker network.

But affected companies did not view the media channel as merely a default communications system. Ray O’Rourke of Morgan Stanley explains: “[Our employees] take real-time news feeds on their desktops. They are very news sensitive. They read it, analyze it, question it. The media were critical for communicating with our employees.”

Oppenheimer’s Rob Densen concurs: “Employees take their cue from the external media, so you need to demonstrate your functionality through the media.” One way Oppenheimer did so was by publishing a full-page letter from Murphy to his employees in the *Wall Street Journal*, *USA Today*, and the *New York Times*.

Some employees will trust a message that has been mediated by independent gatherers and distributors of the

Before any other constructive action can take place – whether it’s serving customers or reassuring investors – the morale of employees must be rebuilt.

Center, wanted to send a message to both its employees and its customers that it would be operational as soon as the markets reopened. So CEO John Murphy appeared on CNBC’s *Squawk Box* to deliver that message. In fact, its contingency site in New Jersey was ready for trading before the markets reopened.

Normally, of course, the news media and corporate America have what may best be described as an adversarial relationship – one that communications officers are asked to “manage.” However, as the events of 9/11 unfolded, many of them realized that they needed to start thinking of the media as allies – in part because their failed communications systems left them no other choice. At Morgan Stanley, the voice mail system serving its 2,700 employees based in

news more than one that comes directly from the company or appears as a paid advertisement. This filtering effect is especially useful at companies where employees tend to be suspicious of statements from management. American Airlines, for instance, has had a history of troubled relations with two of its unions, the Association of Professional Flight Attendants and the Allied Pilots Association. According to Tim Doke, “In a crisis, we usually end up relying on news media to get our message out.... [CEO] Don Carty speaking directly to employees through media outlets such as CNN’s *Larry King Live* and the network morning shows has built bridges and created understanding between management and labor.” In the aftermath of 9/11, both unions waived a num-

ber of the rights of their rank and file to help American Airlines get its planes back in the air.

Although some companies have put computer kiosks on factory floors, the continuous nature of manufacturing operations and the distance of some workers from on-line hookups make communicating via e-mail in such venues difficult. American Airlines found a way around this by using its reservation system to reach as many employees as possible. “[Carty’s] voice mails were transcribed and sent to the SABRE machines—those machines that print your itineraries and tickets—as well as posted on the Internet and e-mailed to employees,” says Doke.

The machines are scattered all over airports, including employee lounges. While their major function is to receive messages, they do have a module permitting the company to communicate with employees, especially those in the field. “The SABRE machines meant that even maintenance people on tarmacs, who might not have Internet access at work, could be kept informed,” Doke says. American Airlines also recorded Carty’s messages on Internet hot lines and posted transcripts of them on its Web site.

To confirm that they were safe, Morgan Stanley’s employees could call one of the toll-free numbers that fed into the company’s Discover Card call centers. The firm also put the number on the ticker display that wraps around its Times Square building. Here, too, the TV networks played a role by broadcasting the number. Quickly, the Discover Card call center became *the* call center during the crisis, even routing calls from non-Morgan Stanley employees looking for information.

Stay Focused on the Business

“Everyone wanted to know what they could do in the wake of 9/11,” says Russell Lewis. “At the New York Times Company, no one had to even ask that question. Our mission is to put out the best newspaper we can so that readers can be as informed as possible. Just like a trauma surgeon, this is what we train

for. There was no question that our employees felt that their job had meaning. And in the end, the *Times* received Pulitzer Prizes for its 9/11 reporting.”

A focus on work, in fact, can be enormously helpful to employees in a time of crisis. It provides an outlet for their desire to help, gets them back into a normal routine, fosters their pride in the company and what they do, and builds strong bonds between themselves and

Operations during a crisis should be decentralized, but decision making should not be.

their customers, many of whom desperately need the company to keep their products and services flowing.

According to Elizabeth Heller Allen, vice president of corporate communications at Dell, “the key was finding an outlet for our employees’ desire to help.” The urgency of getting some 75 of Dell’s customers at Ground Zero and others in the DC area back in business pulled the staff together. At the same time, the senior leadership knew that only a revitalized staff would be able to deliver on Dell’s strong reputation for customer service. A Dell document stated that the objective of its response plan was “to increase employee understanding of how the September 11 terrorist attacks affected Dell’s customers and business and how Dell would respond.” But, other company documents showed, top management knew that Dell’s employees could assist affected customers only if they had a sense of security themselves.

Dell’s business model, which dispenses with the middleman, puts the firm directly in touch with its thousands of customers. Because of that direct contact, employees know exactly what these customers need and want. “We have complete records of what we’ve sold to every customer, so we knew what they had lost,” said Allen. “While it meant working around the clock to get the

computers configured with the correct software, it was our way of giving back.”

Other employees worked those hours to pack and ship systems to the affected customers, who could place orders 24/7. Dell also established service and response teams that customers could reach through dedicated phone lines and the company’s Web site, which gave instructions for obtaining immediate assistance.

“Reaching out to employees struggling with shock, grief, and anger with a more family-like tone enabled us to focus those feelings on responding to our customers’ urgent needs. Maintaining that tone with regular updates more firmly than ever linked our customer-experience strategy to our teams’ everyday work,” says Rollins.

Months after 9/11, the company tried to measure how effective these strategies were. It determined that Dell Helping Rebuild America, an internal Web site, received 54,947 hits in its first two months. The site averaged 603 hits per day, and had 11,016 unique visitors during that period, almost a third of the workforce. In addition, the company asked for feedback from employees and found that 90% thought that Web casts from the CEO and COO during the crisis were helpful and relevant to their jobs and the organization.

Starbucks displayed a similar mixture of head and heart. The chain of coffee shops had a total of 250 branches in New York City’s five boroughs, four of them adjacent to Ground Zero. “A major part of what’s helped us through this was engaging in the relief effort,” Marty Annese, a senior vice president, told a trade publication. The initial “instinctive” response of the company’s crisis management team, according to Chairman Howard Schultz, was to close all company-owned stores in North America so that employees “could return home to be with family and friends,” according to a company statement. Headquarters conveyed this message by voice mail and e-mail to all the stores.

But with the exception of 15 or so stores at the southern end of Manhattan, the New York City branches re-

opened on September 13. Several served food and coffee to rescue workers at Ground Zero, to people at blood donation centers, and to those at the Jacob Javits Convention Center, the command center for volunteer operations during the crisis.

Have a Plan in Place

While many companies have crisis contingency plans and disaster recovery plans in place, few had been tested as rigorously as they were on September 11. As Gregor Bailar, then chief information officer of Nasdaq, commented, "People will have to look very carefully at their backup strategies and see whether they can communicate with everybody easily, whether [critical data] are stored in that same building that could experience [a] disaster."

Having contingency plans means, among other things, establishing contingency work sites. Soon after a truck bomb exploded in the garage of the World Trade Center in 1993, the New York Board of Trade began planning them. By 1995, it had built two sites in the borough of Queens. For six years, they sat empty, costing NYBOT \$300,000 annually in rent and utilities. After September 11, 2001, however, these remote trading pits proved to be one of the best investments NYBOT had ever made.

Web-based communications require their own version of contingency planning. When the destruction of Oppenheimer's Trade Center offices knocked out its intranet Web server, staff moved quickly to post crisis communications on a newly created employee section of the company's Web site. Many other companies also took that approach so that employees who had Internet access at home could stay connected.

Although operations during a crisis should be decentralized, decision making should not be. Airlines have some of the better-developed crisis command centers. At American, the strategic command center is a vast room featuring a large, horseshoe-shaped table with fully equipped workstations and a conference call line that can accommodate as many as 200 outside callers. Large-

screen televisions set up to receive satellite broadcasts allow command center employees to monitor all news coverage of the crisis.

Messages should also be sent from a centralized source. At Oppenheimer Funds, Bob Neihoff, then manager of contingency planning, called a designated number within moments of the attack, punched in some information, and activated the company's crisis plan. Employees already knew to call into the Denver operation, which assumed control of the technology running the Web sites and voice mail systems. However, the substance of all communications came from Densen, the corporate affairs director, and CEO Murphy in New York City.

A widely circulated toll-free number can help ensure that employees obtain information from a single authorized source. Because Verizon had such a number, its 250,000 employees nationwide were able to access recorded messages containing the latest information about the crisis. Morgan Stanley's toll-free number was televised as early as 11:00 AM on September 11, making it, according to President and COO Bob Scott, "the first national emergency number of any organization, including the federal government." By 1:30 PM that day, the firm's crisis center had received more than 2,500 calls.

Finally, many executives I spoke with emphasized how important it was to have experienced communications professionals on board. These people were panic proof, executives said. "The advantage of communications veterans," adds American Airline's Tim Doke, "is that they have done everything, so in a crisis you can easily pull them out of one job and put them in another."

Improvise, but from a Strong Foundation

"All of the planning that you do for a crisis helps you get through the basics," says the New York Stock Exchange's Robert Zito, its executive vice president for communications. Still, "people need to think on their feet and make quick decisions. Until the crisis comes, in what-

ever form, you don't really understand how valuable all the preparation was."

There is more to preparation than training. As important is instilling in employees the firm's values. Although Starbucks ordered its 2,900 North American stores closed within a few hours of the attacks, the managers of several undamaged stores near the disaster site decided on their own initiative to stay open, a few all night, to provide coffee and pastries to hospital staffs and rescue workers. Others served as triage centers for the injured. People who had been wandering the streets of lower Manhattan in a daze were grabbed by Starbucks employees and pulled inside—and in some cases, lives were saved when nearby buildings collapsed.

One of the eight precepts recited in Starbucks' mission statement is, "Contribute positively to our communities

Employees will know what to do in a crisis only if they have been absorbing the company's guiding principles all along.

and our environment." Many of Starbucks' outlets are, even in Manhattan, neighborhood-gathering places, full of comfortable chairs in which customers may linger for hours. Essentially, they had helped bring together the community they served.

Goldman Sachs's neighborhood is, in the abstract, the global marketplace, but its employees' dedication to this community couldn't have been fiercer. In one of his regular voice mails, Goldman Sachs CEO Henry Paulson saw something of the typical bond trader's agility and coolness under fire in his employees' ability to cope with a disabled transportation system. "Getting to work remains very difficult," he said. "Many routes are sealed off or closed. But that hasn't stopped you....The police stepped in and stopped the buses [you char-

tered]. So one of you had the clever idea to secure ferryboats. What you couldn't do by land you did by sea. Today, the idea of special buses with police escorts was a winner. And every colleague who needed to be in the office was here."

That may have been due, in part, to other remarks Paulson had made. "Our assets will always be our people, capital, and reputation, with our people being the most important of the three.... And the lesson here is that our principles will never fail us as long as we do not fail to live up to them."

Goldman Sachs employees weren't the only ones using nautical approaches to get to the office. At the *New York Times*, Russell Lewis told us that one reporter kayaked across the Hudson River to get to work.

Many of the executives we spoke with emphasized that a company cannot start communicating its mission and vision during a crisis. Employees will know what to do only if they have been absorbing the company's guiding prin-

ciples all along. Two of Oppenheimer's shared values, according to an internal document, are "dedication to caring" and "team spirit." Thinking back to 9/11, CEO John Murphy says, "If you have a strong culture, you have the ability to maintain focus. On 9/11, we had a structure, a belief system, and a hierarchy all in place. That helped us to get through the crisis, and we haven't skipped a beat since."

The company had one more advantage: a communications strategy, which succeeded in reminding its employees and the world of those assets. When the markets reopened, Oppenheimer, the only mutual fund manager in the towers, had one of the largest net inflows of any broker-sold fund family in the United States.

The most forward-thinking leaders realize that managing a crisis communications program requires the same dedication and resources they typically give to other dimensions of their business. They also realize that a strong in-

ternal communications function allows them not only to weather a crisis but to strengthen their organization internally.

Just as a death in the family often brings people closer together, so did the catastrophe on 9/11. Many of the executives I interviewed talked about how their companies sustained that sense of community long after 9/11 by keeping the lines of communication open. At the *New York Times*, the strength of these bonds was tested soon after the terrorist attacks when a reporter received an envelope containing a white powder suspected to be anthrax. Once again, Russell Lewis and other senior executives went on the public address system. "For that time period," he recalls, "we were a family, and that doesn't wear off, as long as you are consistent in your concern for coworkers." 

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